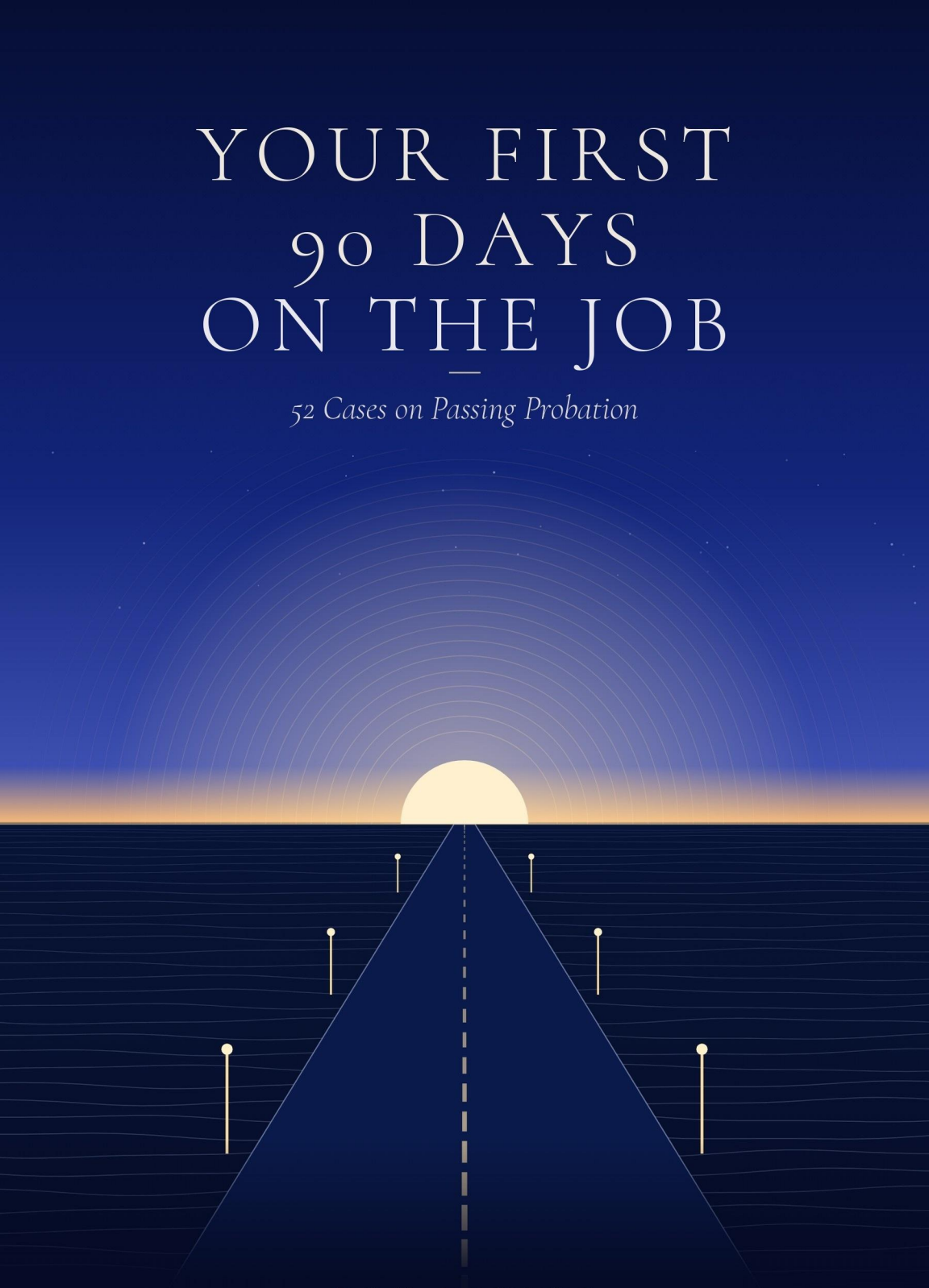
YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS ON THE JOB

52 Cases on Passing Probation



RON TAYLOR

executiveclass.ca

AN EXECUTIVE CLASS SERIES BY RON TAYLOR

YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS ON THE JOB

52 CASES FOR BRAZILIAN PROFESSIONALS ON PASSING PROBATION

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Your First 90 Days on the Job

52 Cases for Brazilian Professionals on Passing Probation

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The people and companies described in this book are composites. Their names are invented. Office Listening Lab scripts are referenced by number and title.

Employment rules, benefits and probation terms vary by employer and by province or territory. Nothing in this book is legal advice; check your own contract and your provincial government's official information.

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An Executive Class Series by Ron Taylor

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First edition

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

You got the job. Parabéns. Now comes the part nobody teaches: the first 90 days, when your employer decides whether you stay.

This book is for Brazilian professionals with solid experience back home who have just started their first job in Canada. Your English was good enough to pass the interview. Now it has to carry you through meetings, emails, feedback and a hundred small moments where the words are easy but the meaning isn't. You don't need to learn how to do your job. You need to learn how it is read here.

The book is written in English on purpose. You work in English every day now, and reading about work in English is part of the practice. Where a Portuguese word makes a point sharper, you'll find it. Every case ends with a short **Em resumo**, so the key idea is anchored in your own language too.

How each case works

There are 52 cases in four parts that follow the probation calendar. Each case has the same shape:

1. **The case**: a typical office situation.
2. **What was going on**: the unwritten rule behind it.
3. **English models**: the exact phrases that work.
4. **Vocabulary**: key terms, with the Portuguese beside them.
5. **Practice**: two or three short exercises. Answers are in the Answer Key at the back.
6. **Listen next**: the matching script in the Office Listening Lab, so you can hear the language in a full conversation.

7. **Em resumo**: the case in one Portuguese sentence.

The most important rule in this book: reputation

In your first 90 days you are building a reputation, whether you like it or not. Every arrival, every email and every meeting becomes part of the story your team tells about you. That story forms fast and changes slowly.

So start two simple habits on day one:

1. **Arrive early.** Ten or fifteen minutes before start time. Not to be seen, but to begin the day organized, coffee in hand and computer on when the team walks in. (If you are paid by the hour, these minutes are for organizing yourself, not for doing work; check how your employer records time.)
2. **After finishing time, take ten minutes to write notes.** The names you learned, what you understood, what you promised and to whom, and your questions for tomorrow. These notes become your memory of probation and the raw material for every conversation with your manager.

Your boss will probably say, "You don't have to do that." They are being kind, and they are right: it isn't required. Do it anyway. Nobody will ask for those ten minutes, but everyone will notice the professional they build.

You will meet this idea in every part of the book. Every case is, at heart, about the reputation you are building.

The unwritten rules

Every company has written policies and expectations nobody writes down. The unwritten ones weigh most during probation, because nobody will explain them to you. People who grew up here simply know.

This book teaches dozens of these rules. But every office has its own, and they change from company to company, industry to industry and city to city. A bank in Toronto doesn't run like a startup in Montreal. So the most useful skill isn't memorizing rules. It's **observing**.

In your first weeks, watch:

1. **How colleagues talk to the manager.** How formal? By email, chat or in person?
2. **How much independence is expected.** Do people solve things alone or check in often?
3. **How meetings run.** Who speaks, when, and for how long?
4. **How people disagree.** Openly, with questions, or later, in private?
5. **How information moves.** In meetings, emails, chat, the hallway?
6. **How people ask for help.** Whom they ask, how, and how quickly.

Then join this habit to your notes: every day after hours, write down one unwritten rule you noticed. In 90 days you'll have a manual of your own company that no book could write.

Adapting doesn't mean accepting everything

This book is about adapting: how you speak, disagree and ask. But adapting to a workplace culture doesn't mean accepting mistreatment. Your rights as a worker apply from day one, including during probation. They depend on your work situation and your province or territory. If something feels wrong, check your provincial government's official information on employment rights before you decide what to do.

A suggested pace

Read four cases a week. In 13 weeks you finish the book and, if all goes well, your probation too.

Your First 90 Days on the Job course

This book is also a course. **Your First 90 Days on the Job** turns these cases into live, one-on-one practice online: thirteen weekly lessons, one for each week of your probation, in which you rehearse the conversations, emails, meetings and reviews of your first three months before they happen for real. Details at **executiveclass.ca**.

PART ONE

THE FIRST DAYS

In your first three weeks, nobody expects you to know everything. They expect you to learn fast, ask well and be easy to work with. The 13 cases in this part cover the first day, the rules nobody writes down, and your first private conversation with your manager.

CASE 1

What Probation Really Tests

The case

Fernanda had nine years in supply chain in Ribeirão Preto when she started as an analyst at a distributor in Burnaby. On her first Monday, her manager, Dave, asked her to look at last quarter's delivery delays. "No rush," he said. "Just get a feel for the data."

Fernanda decided to impress. She spent ten days head down, barely speaking in meetings, and delivered a 30-page report with three forecasting models. It was the best work she had ever done.

In their week-three one-on-one, Dave praised the report. Then he said, "Honestly, I was expecting a quick one-pager. Next time, give me a heads-up on where you're going before you go deep. And I'd love to hear more from you in meetings."

Fernanda left the room confused. The work was excellent. Why did the conversation feel like criticism?

What was going on

Fernanda's technical skill had already been tested. That's why she was hired. Probation tests something else. Most Canadian managers have four questions in mind:

1. **Do you understand what was asked?** "Get a feel for the data" asked for a quick look, not a project. When a request is vague, the right question is worth more than extra work.
2. **Do you flag things early?** Ten days without news leaves a manager in the dark. Here, a short update halfway through is a sign of professionalism, not insecurity.
3. **Are you easy to work with?** Silence in meetings is usually read as lack of interest or opinion, not as respect.
4. **Do you learn fast?** Your manager wants to see you adjust after the first piece of feedback.

In Brazil, your work often speaks for you. In Canada it speaks too, but the communication around it speaks first. Probation often lasts three months, sometimes six; your contract sets the exact period and who does the review.

Behind the four questions is a single one: **what reputation are you building?** In three weeks, Fernanda already had one: *brilliant, but disappears and doesn't speak.* The good news is that reputation is built with small habits. Arrive early. After hours, write down what you learned and what you promised. Flag things before you need to. Dave will never ask for any of it, but he will notice all of it.

English models

To understand the request:

- "Just so I'm clear, are you looking for a quick overview or a full analysis?"
- "Before I go too deep on this, can I check I'm heading in the right direction?"

To flag early:

- "Quick heads-up: this is taking a bit longer than I expected. I should have it to you by Thursday."
- "I'll have a first draft to you by Wednesday."

To find out what will be evaluated:

- "What would success look like for me at the end of the first 90 days?"
- "Is there anything you'd like me to do differently?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
probation period	período de experiência
heads-up	aviso antecipado
to go deep	se aprofundar (às vezes demais)
a one-pager	um resumo de uma página
to get a feel for	ter uma noção geral de
to ramp up	ganhar ritmo no novo trabalho
a good fit	alguém que se encaixa bem na equipe

Practice

A. Dave said, "No rush, just get a feel for the data." What was he expecting to receive? Answer in one sentence.

B. Rewrite this message as a professional heads-up:

> *The report is late.*

C. Write the question you will ask your manager this week about what will be evaluated in your probation.

Listen next

Office Lab 8, Your First Project. Karen explains to Larissa what it means to "own" a task and when to send a heads-up (you'll hear it again in Case 9). Listen for how she says the deadline is flexible, but she still expects a message if it slips.

Em resumo: No probation, a sua competência já foi comprovada; o que está sendo avaliado é a reputação que você constrói, um hábito pequeno de cada vez.

CASE 2

The First Morning

The case

Rafael started at an engineering consultancy in Toronto on a Monday in September. His welcome email said, "We start at 9." He arrived at exactly 9:00, pleased with his punctuality.

The receptionist was on the phone. His manager, Susan, was already in a meeting. A colleague, Mike, came to get him at 9:20, a little rushed: "Sorry,

it's a crazy Monday. Did you want a coffee?" Rafael said, "No, thank you," because he thought the question was just politeness. He spent the morning waiting for his laptop, not sure where to sit.

At 5 p.m., Susan stopped by his desk. "Great first day? Go home, you don't have to stay." Rafael left right away, tired, unable to remember half the names he had heard.

What was going on

In most Canadian offices, "we start at 9" means you are working at 9, not arriving at 9. If you walk in at 9:00 sharp, you start the day catching up: taking off your coat, finding your desk, turning on your computer while everyone else is already moving.

Rafael did nothing wrong. But he also did nothing to start building the reputation he wanted. And reputation starts on day one.

Three moments from his morning:

- **"Did you want a coffee?"** uses the past tense to sound polite, not to talk about the past. It's a real offer, and accepting it is a way to start a five-minute conversation with Mike.
- **"Go home, you don't have to stay"** is true. Nobody expects you to stay. But the ten minutes after hours are yours, not the company's: use them to write down names, roles and what you learned.
- **Waiting for the laptop** is normal on day one. Use the time to ask about the team, the week ahead and who's who.

English models

When you arrive:

- "Good morning! I'm Rafael, I'm starting today on Susan's team."
- "I'd love a coffee, thanks. How do you take yours?"

While you wait:

- "While I'm waiting for the laptop, is there anything I can read to get up to speed?"
- "Who should I make sure to meet this week?"

At the end of the day:

- "Thanks for a great first day. What time does the team usually get in?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
we start at 9	começamos a trabalhar às 9 (não: chegamos às 9)
to get in	chegar ao trabalho
to get up to speed	se atualizar, pegar o ritmo
a crazy Monday	uma segunda-feira corrida
you don't have to	você não precisa (não é obrigatório)
to settle in	se acomodar, se adaptar

Practice

A. Mike asks, "Did you want a coffee?" Write an answer that accepts the offer and starts a conversation.

B. The email says, "We start at 9." What time should you arrive, and why?

C. Write the four notes you would make after hours on your first day: names, what you learned, what you promised, questions.

Listen next

Office Lab 1, First Morning. Larissa arrives at reception. Listen for "Did you want a coffee?" in the first lines, and for what "on the company" means.

Em resumo: "We start at 9" quer dizer trabalhando às 9; chegue antes, aceite o café e use os dez minutos depois do horário para anotar o seu primeiro dia.

CASE 3

Twenty Seconds to Introduce Yourself

The case

At her first team meeting at a software company in Vancouver, Juliana's manager said, "Juliana, why don't you introduce yourself?"

Juliana had prepared a full presentation. She spoke for almost three minutes: her university, her two MBAs, her twelve-year career, her four previous jobs, her main projects. The team listened politely. After the meeting, nobody mentioned anything she had said.

The same week, a new colleague named Kevin introduced himself in twenty seconds: "Hi everyone, I'm Kevin. I'm joining as a data analyst. I spent the last five years in retail analytics in Calgary. Outside work, I'm trying to learn to ski. Really looking forward to working with you all." By lunch, three people were talking to him about skiing.

What was going on

In Canada, introducing yourself to the team is not an interview. You've already been hired. The goal is to give people a reason to talk to you later.

A long introduction full of achievements can sound like a need to prove your worth. Degrees and awards belong in an interview. With your team, your years of experience are enough: "I have 12 years of experience in fintech." A short introduction with one personal detail opens doors. Kevin gave the team an easy question: "How's the skiing going?"

The twenty-second formula:

1. **Name and role.**
2. **One sentence of experience.** Just one, the most relevant to this team.
3. **One personal detail.** Something light that invites a question.
4. **A closing line.**

The rest of your story you tell bit by bit, in one-on-one conversations. That's how reputation is built: in many small conversations, not in one speech.

English models

- "Hi everyone, I'm Juliana. I'm joining as a product manager."
- "I have twelve years of experience in fintech, most recently in São Paulo."
- "I just moved here in August, so any coffee recommendations are welcome."
- "Really looking forward to working with you all."

When someone asks more later:

- "Happy to tell you more over a coffee sometime."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to introduce yourself	se apresentar
to be joining as	estar entrando como (cargo)
background	formação, experiência anterior
looking forward to	ansioso para (no bom sentido)
an icebreaker	algo que quebra o gelo

Practice

A. Write your own twenty-second introduction using the four-part formula.

B. Which of these sentences shouldn't be in a team introduction? Why?

1. "I'm joining as a senior accountant."
2. "I have two master's degrees and I was the top performer in my last three companies."
3. "I'm a big hockey fan, still learning the rules."

Listen next

Office Lab 2, Meet the Team. Larissa meets her new team. Listen for "Can I grab you for a second?" and "He's your guy."

Em resumo: Para a equipe, apresente-se em vinte segundos: nome, função, uma frase de experiência e um detalhe pessoal; os diplomas ficam para a entrevista.

CASE 4

Passwords, Systems and the First Question

The case

Thiago joined an insurance company in Calgary as a financial analyst. On his second day, he couldn't get into the reporting system. He tried his password several times, read the intranet manual and restarted his computer.

He didn't want to bother anyone. *Todo mundo está ocupado, e eu sou o novo,* he thought. He spent Tuesday and Wednesday trying on his own and reading old documents.

On Thursday, his manager, Linda, asked how the report was going. When Thiago explained, she was surprised: "Why didn't you just ping IT? It takes them five minutes." It wasn't a reprimand. But Thiago felt he had lost two days.

What was going on

In Brazil, many professionals learn to solve things alone so they don't look dependent. In Canada, in your first days, the opposite is true: asking quickly shows you value everyone's time.

A practical rule: **if you've been stuck for more than 30 minutes on an access or system problem, ask.** Nobody expects you to know the passwords, the shortcuts or the right people in your first week.

What Linda saw wasn't a lack of ability. It was two days of silence. And during probation, silence is the worst thing for your reputation.

English models

To IT support:

- "Hi, I'm new on the finance team. I've been trying to log in to the reporting system for about an hour and I keep getting an error. Could you help?"

To a colleague:

- "Have you got a second? Who's the best person to ask about system access?"

To your manager:

- "Quick heads-up: I'm waiting on access to the reporting system. IT is on it, so I'm reading the old reports in the meantime."

When the problem is fixed, you'll hear:

- "You're all set."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to log in	entrar no sistema
to be locked out	estar bloqueado, sem acesso
to ping someone	mandar uma mensagem rápida
a ticket	uma solicitação de suporte
you're all set	está tudo pronto
in the meantime	enquanto isso

Practice

A. You've been unable to open your email for an hour. Write the message to IT support.

B. Fill in the blank: "I'm waiting on access. IT is on it, so I'm reading the manual in the _____."

C. True or false: in your first week, asking for help with systems shows a lack of independence.

Listen next

Office Lab 3, Laptop and Passwords. Larissa gets her laptop and passwords. Listen for "You've got," where the "'ve" almost disappears. Then try Office Lab 9, Asking for Help.

Em resumo: Travou num sistema por mais de 30 minutos? Pergunte; no Canadá, o silêncio pesa mais na reputação do que a pergunta.

CASE 5

The Kitchen Rules

The case

Camila had been at a marketing agency in Mississauga for a week. On Friday, she left her mug and lunch container in the kitchen sink, as she always had at her office in Curitiba, where the *copeira* washed everything at the end of the day.

On Monday there was a note taped above the sink: "Friendly reminder: please wash your own dishes. Thanks! :)" Nobody said anything to her. But at coffee time, Camila noticed two colleagues glance at the sink and then at her.

What was going on

Every company has unwritten rules, and the kitchen is where they show up first. Nobody explains them, because to people who grew up here they seem obvious. "Friendly reminder" notes with a smiley face are often passive-aggressive: polite in form, annoyed in content.

The most common Canadian kitchen rules:

- Wash and put away your own mug and containers. There is no *copeira*.
- Put your name and the date on food in the fridge.
- Many offices empty the fridge on Friday. Whatever is left goes in the garbage.
- Clean the microwave if your food splatters.
- Avoid heating fish or strong-smelling food in a shared microwave.
- If you took the last coffee, make a new pot.

The kitchen is small, but the reputation formed there is big. People who look after shared spaces are seen as people who look after the team.

English models

To learn the rules before you break one:

- "Is there anything I should know about how things work in the kitchen?"
- "Is it okay if I leave this in the fridge until Friday?"

If you get it wrong:

- "Sorry, that was mine. I didn't realize. It won't happen again."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
unwritten rules	regras não escritas
passive-aggressive	agressivo de forma indireta
a friendly reminder	um lembrete “amigável” (às vezes irritado)
to read between the lines	ler nas entrelinhas
shared space	espaço comum
to label	etiquetar, colocar nome

Practice

A. The note says, “Friendly reminder: please wash your own dishes. Thanks! :)” Is the writer relaxed or annoyed? How do you know?

B. Write the question you would ask a colleague on your first day to learn the kitchen rules.

Listen next

Office Lab 4, The Kitchen Rules. Rodrigo explains the office kitchen to Larissa. Listen for “unwritten rules,” “passive-aggressive” and “read between the lines.”

Em resumo: Na cozinha canadense não existe copeira: cada um cuida do que é seu, e quem cuida do espaço comum ganha fama de cuidar da equipe.

CASE 6

Monday Small Talk

The case

Bruno arrived at an energy company in Calgary on a Monday morning. At the coffee machine, his colleague Jenny asked, "Hey Bruno, how was your weekend?"

Bruno was honest. His weekend had been terrible: the heater in his apartment broke, the landlord didn't answer, he slept in his coat and then fought with his phone company. Jenny listened, said, "Oh no, that's rough," and went back to her desk with her coffee.

The next Monday, Bruno just said, "Normal." Jenny smiled and didn't ask anything else. The conversation ended there.

What was going on

Canadian small talk follows a simple script: **a short, positive answer, one detail, and the same question back.** The question isn't a request for a report. It's an invitation to thirty seconds of connection.

The first week, Bruno said too much. The second, too little. "Normal" closes the door, because it gives the other person nothing to continue with.

The version that works: "Pretty good, thanks! I finally went to Banff. How about you?" One sentence, one detail, the question back.

Safe topics: the weather, the weekend, sports (hockey, above all), food, travel, shows. Topics to avoid early on: salary, politics, religion and personal problems. Save the *desabafo* for your friends.

Small talk looks small, but it's where the team decides whether you're easy to be around. And that, again, is reputation.

English models

Answering:

- "Pretty good, thanks! We tried a new Brazilian place downtown. How was yours?"
- "Quiet, which was exactly what I needed. Did you get up to anything fun?"

When the weekend really was bad:

- "Could've been better, but I survived! How about you?"

Asking:

- "What did you get up to on the weekend?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
small talk	conversa leve, de cortesia
what did you get up to?	o que você fez?
that's rough	que difícil
could've been better	poderia ter sido melhor
to catch up	colocar a conversa em dia

Practice

A. Answer using the script (short answer, one detail, question back): "How was your weekend?"

B. Why does “Normal.” end the conversation?

C. Which topics are safe for small talk in your first week? Hockey · your salary · the weather · elections · a new restaurant

Listen next

Office Lab 5, Monday Small Talk. Monday morning at the coffee machine. Notice how every answer is short and ends with a question.

Em resumo: Small talk é uma resposta curta e positiva, um detalhe e a pergunta de volta; nem relatório, nem “normal”.

CASE 7

Lunch and Separate Bills

The case

In her second week at a logistics company in Montreal, Patrícia’s team invited her to lunch. She was delighted and ordered a starter, a main course and dessert, the way she would at a business lunch in São Paulo.

Her colleagues ordered a sandwich or a salad. By 12:40, everyone was checking the time. When the server asked, “Together or separate?”, someone said, “Separate bills, please,” before Patrícia could suggest splitting it. She tipped 10% and saw a colleague leave 18%.

Walking back, Patrícia realized the lunch had lasted 45 minutes and she had been the last to finish.

What was going on

A Canadian team lunch is short, simple, and everyone pays for their own. It isn't stinginess. It keeps everyone comfortable: nobody pays for someone else's expensive dish, and nobody ends up owing anyone.

Three practical rules:

- **Time:** usually 30 to 60 minutes. Many people eat at their desks. A group lunch is an occasion, but not a long one.
- **The bill:** "separate bills" is the default. If someone says, "It's on the company," the company pays.
- **The tip:** at table-service restaurants, 15% to 20% is normal.

And the most important rule: **accept the first invitations.** In your first weeks, lunch with the team is one of the fastest ways to stop being "the new person" and become part of the group.

English models

Accepting:

- "I'd love to, thanks for asking!"

At the restaurant:

- "Separate bills, please."
- "Could I get the soup and sandwich combo?"

If you can't go:

- "I can't today, but please ask me again. I'd love to join next time."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
separate bills	contas separadas
it's on the company	a empresa paga
tip	gorjeta
to grab lunch	almoçar (informal)
to join	ir junto, participar

Practice

A. The server asks, "Together or separate?" What's the usual answer at a team lunch?

B. The bill comes to $20. What's a normal tip?

C. You can't go to lunch today, but you want to be invited again. Write your answer.

Listen next

Office Lab 6, Team Lunch. Larissa at a restaurant with her team. Listen for the tip: Karen says "eighteen," not "eighty." Notice the stress on the last syllable.

Em resumo: Almoço de equipe é curto, cada um paga o seu e a gorjeta é de 15% a 20%; aceite os primeiros convites.

CASE 8

Asking About Benefits

The case

In his first week at a tech company in Waterloo, Gustavo received an HR envelope: forms for a health plan, a dental plan and a retirement program where the company added money to his own contributions. The HR analyst said, "Just fill these out when you can. You know the drill."

Gustavo didn't know the drill. He was embarrassed to ask what the terms meant, and the envelope went into a drawer. Two months later, at the dentist, he discovered he wasn't enrolled. The deadline to join had passed.

What was going on

The Canadian benefits system is different from the Brazilian one, and nobody expects you to know it. "You know the drill" is just an automatic phrase. The HR analyst assumed he knew, and he didn't correct her.

A few things that are often true, but confirm them with your employer:

- Many plans have an **enrolment deadline**, often in the first 30 to 60 days.
- Some benefits only start **after probation**.
- Some retirement programs offer **matching**: the company adds money when you contribute. If you don't sign up, you leave that money on the table.

Asking about benefits doesn't make you look interested only in money. It makes you look organized. Understanding HR is part of your reputation too: you're someone who takes care of the details.

English models

- "Sorry, this is all new to me. Could you walk me through these forms?"
- "Is there a deadline to sign up for the health plan?"
- "When do my benefits start?"
- "Does the company match contributions?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
benefits	benefícios
health / dental plan	plano de saúde / odontológico
to sign up, to enrol	se inscrever
deadline	prazo final
matching	contrapartida da empresa
you know the drill	você já conhece a rotina
to walk someone through	explicar passo a passo

Practice

A. What does "You know the drill" mean? What should Gustavo have said?

B. Write three questions you would ask HR in your first week.

Listen next

Office Lab 7, Paperwork and Benefits. Larissa with HR. Listen for the numbers: two forms, every two weeks, three months, three weeks, five days. The benefits in the script are examples, not a real employer's.

Em resumo: Ninguém espera que você conheça os benefícios canadenses; pergunte na primeira semana e não perca o prazo de inscrição.

CASE 9

What "Own It" Means

The case

In her third week at a retail chain in Edmonton, Aline's manager said, "I'd like you to own the new supplier onboarding. Talk to procurement and legal, and let me know if you hit any walls."

Aline waited for detailed instructions. When she needed to send the first email to legal, she asked her manager for permission. Then she asked for approval of the wording. Then she asked whether she could book a meeting with procurement. At the fourth question, her manager answered with a tired smile: "You don't need to check with me on that. It's yours."

What was going on

In many Brazilian companies, hierarchy means asking for authorization before acting. In Canada, when your manager says "own it," they are handing you the whole responsibility: deciding the steps, tracking the deadlines, talking to people and reporting progress.

"Own it" doesn't mean working alone and in silence. It means:

1. **Decide** the next steps without asking permission for each one.
2. **Follow up** on what others promised, with a gentle nudge when they're late.
3. **Inform** your manager with short, regular updates.

4. **Flag early** when you hit a wall.

The difference is subtle: you don't ask permission, but you keep your manager informed. People who do this well quickly earn the most valuable reputation in any office: *I don't have to worry about it if she's on it.*

There's one step further. When you hit a wall, don't bring your manager only the problem. Bring one or two possible solutions as well. Many Canadian managers expect this from someone who owns a task. It shows initiative and judgment, and the decision is still theirs. The exception is regulated, safety-sensitive or high-risk work, where you follow procedure and ask for guidance before acting.

English models

Updating your manager:

- "Quick update on the supplier onboarding: legal has the contract, and I'm meeting procurement on Thursday."

Nudging a colleague:

- "Hi Tom, just giving you a nudge on the contract review. Any update?"

When you hit a wall, with solutions:

- "I've hit a wall with legal. The contracts are taking two weeks each. I see two options: we use a standard template, or we book a weekly review slot. Which would work better?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to own (a task)	ser o responsável total por

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
it's yours	é sua responsabilidade
to hit a wall	travar, encontrar um obstáculo
a nudge	um lembrete gentil
to be on it	estar cuidando disso
to check with someone	consultar alguém antes

Practice

A. Which of these are part of owning a task? Asking approval for every email · sending short updates · flagging when you're stuck · waiting for instructions

B. Write a gentle nudge to a colleague who promised to send you data yesterday.

C. You've hit a problem on your project. Write a message to your manager that brings two possible solutions.

Listen next

Office Lab 8, Your First Project. Karen gives Larissa her first project. Listen for "own," "heads-up" and "give him a nudge."

Em resumo: "Own it" é assumir a tarefa inteira: decidir, acompanhar, informar e, quando travar, levar o problema junto com uma solução.

CASE 10

Asking Without Looking Lost

The case

Diego was a senior software engineer in Florianópolis. At his new job in Ottawa, he had lots of questions about the code and the company's processes. To avoid bothering anyone too much, he sent his colleague Ryan short messages throughout the day: "Where is the config file?" An hour later: "How do I run the tests?" Later still: "Where is the config file again?"

On Friday, Ryan answered the repeat question with a link and no words at all. Diego realized he had a problem.

What was going on

Asking is good. Diego's problem wasn't his questions; it was the way he asked them: interruptions all day, no context, and the same question twice. That makes a very capable person look lost.

The method that works:

1. **Try for 15 to 30 minutes first.** Check the documentation, the intranet, the chat history.
2. **Batch your questions.** Three questions in one message are less disruptive than three interruptions.
3. **Show what you've already tried.** It proves you thought before you asked.
4. **Write the answer down.** Never ask the same question twice. That's exactly what your end-of-day notes are for.

A well-asked question builds a reputation for care. A scattered, repeated one builds the opposite.

English models

- "Have you got a second? I've got three quick questions about the deployment process."
- "I've been trying to run the tests locally. I've checked the README, but I keep getting this error. What am I missing?"
- "Is there a good place to look this up, so I don't have to bother you next time?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
have you got a second?	você tem um minutinho?
what's up?	o que foi?, do que você precisa?
I've been trying	estou tentando (há algum tempo)
what am I missing?	o que eu não estou vendo?
to look something up	procurar uma informação
to bother someone	incomodar alguém

Practice

A. Rewrite Diego's question so it shows what he has already tried.

> *Where is the config file?*

B. Put the four steps in order: write the answer down · try on your own · show what you tried · batch your questions.

Listen next

Office Lab 9, Asking for Help. Larissa asks Rodrigo for help. Listen for "Have you got a second?" and the verb tense in "I've been trying."

Em resumo: Tente sozinho primeiro, junte as perguntas, mostre o que já tentou e anote a resposta: assim a pergunta constrói reputação.

CASE 11

Sorry, Sorry, Sorry

The case

Renata was walking down the hallway of a bank in Halifax when a colleague bumped into her and said, "Sorry!" A minute later, she bumped into someone else, and that person said, "Oh, sorry!" Renata found it strange: the one who got bumped was apologizing.

That afternoon, she thanked a colleague for help with a spreadsheet, and he answered, "No worries!" Renata didn't understand: *preocupação com o quê?*

What was going on

Many Canadians say "sorry" a lot, and it's rarely a formal apology. Most of the time it's a way of keeping things smooth.

"Sorry" can mean:

- **I apologize** (a real apology).
- **Excuse me** ("Sorry, can I just squeeze past?").
- **Pardon?** ("Sorry?" with rising intonation, when you didn't hear).
- **I feel bad for you** ("Sorry to hear that").

And when someone says thank you, the most common replies aren't "You're welcome," but "No worries," "No problem," "Anytime" and "You bet."

The lesson for Brazilians has two sides. First, use "sorry" and "thanks" even more than you would in Brazil: it sounds friendly, not weak. Second, don't read other people's "sorry" as an admission of fault. In a meeting, "Sorry, can I add something?" is just a polite way to take the floor.

Small courtesies add up to a big part of your reputation: someone pleasant to have around.

English models

- "Sorry, can I just squeeze past?"
- "Sorry? I didn't catch that."
- "Sorry to hear that. I hope you feel better."
- When someone thanks you: "No worries!" / "Anytime!"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
sorry?	como?, pode repetir?
to squeeze past	passar espremido
I didn't catch that	não entendi, não ouvi
no worries	de nada, tranquilo
anytime / you bet	sempre que precisar / de nada

Practice

A. What does "sorry" mean in each sentence? (1) "Sorry, I'm late." (2) "Sorry? Could you repeat that?" (3) "Sorry to hear about your dad."

B. A colleague says, “Thanks so much for your help!” Give two natural replies.

Listen next

Office Lab 47, Sorry, Sorry, Sorry, and Office Lab 48, No Worries. Listen to the intonation of “Sorry?” when it means “I didn’t hear you.”

Em resumo: No Canadá, “sorry” quase nunca é admissão de culpa; use “sorry” e “thanks” sem economia e responda aos agradecimentos com “no worries”.

CASE 12

Names, Accents and Your Own Name

The case

In his first week at a construction company in Vancouver, Marcelo’s colleagues called him “Marsello,” “Marcel” and even “Mark.” He didn’t correct anyone, to avoid embarrassment. By the end of the month, half the office called him Mark, and he didn’t like it.

Meanwhile, Marcelo was too embarrassed to say his colleague Siobhan’s name. He didn’t know how to pronounce it, so for three weeks he just said, “Hi!”

What was going on

In Canada, where almost every office has names from many countries, correcting how people say your name is normal and expected. People would rather be corrected on day one than find out three months later that they’ve been getting it wrong.

The same goes the other way: asking how to pronounce someone's name is a sign of respect, never of ignorance. Siobhan is pronounced "shi-VAWN," and she has heard that question hundreds of times.

You can keep your name as it is or use a simpler version. Both are fine. What matters is that it's your choice, not something that happened because you said nothing.

A practical tip: in your end-of-day notes, write each new name with its pronunciation, spelled your own way. Remembering names is one of the fastest ways to build a good reputation.

English models

Teaching your name:

- "It's actually Mar-SEH-lo, but don't worry, everyone gets it wrong at first."
- "You can call me Marcelo, or Marc if that's easier."

Asking:

- "Sorry, how do you pronounce your name?"
- "Could you spell that for me?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to pronounce	pronunciar
to spell	soletrar
to get it wrong	errar
to go by (a name)	ser chamado de

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
a nickname	apelido

Practice

A. Write how you would teach someone to pronounce your own name.

B. You've forgotten the name of a colleague you met yesterday. Write a polite way to ask again.

Listen next

Office Lab 43, Spelling a Name. A phone call where someone spells the name Siobhan. Listen for "Could you spell that for me?" and "I'll let you go."

Em resumo: Corrija a pronúncia do seu nome logo no primeiro dia e pergunte sem vergonha como se diz o nome dos outros; lembrar nomes é reputação.

CASE 13

The First One-on-One

The case

Beatriz was at the end of her third week at a healthcare company in Toronto when her manager, Priya, booked their first one-on-one. Beatriz walked in with nothing prepared, expecting an evaluation.

Priya asked, "So, how are things going?" Beatriz said, "Fine, everything's good." Priya asked if she had any questions. "No, I'm okay." The meeting, booked for 30 minutes, ended in 10.

Afterwards, Beatriz remembered everything she had wanted to say: a question about priorities, a problem with a system, an idea for the weekly report.

What was going on

A one-on-one is a regular, private meeting with your manager, and in Canada it belongs to **you**, not to the manager. They expect you to bring the agenda. "How are things going?" is an open invitation, and "Fine" wastes it.

In your first 90 days, the one-on-one is where your reputation is discussed out loud. Use it.

A simple three-part agenda:

1. **What I've done** since we last talked.
2. **What I'm working on** now.
3. **Where I need help.**

In your first one-on-one, also ask two questions that will guide your whole probation: what success looks like at 90 days, and how your manager prefers to get updates.

The notes you take after hours every day become a ready-made agenda. This is where the habit starts to pay off.

English models

- "I've put together a few points, if that's okay."
- "This week I finished the onboarding modules and started on the weekly report."
- "I could use your help with access to the patient database."
- "What would a successful first 90 days look like for you?"

- "How do you prefer to get updates: email, chat, or here in our one-on-ones?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
one-on-one	reunião individual com o manager
agenda	pauta
to put together	preparar, organizar
I could use your help	eu precisaria da sua ajuda
that's a win	isso é uma vitória
every second Tuesday	a cada duas terças-feiras

Practice

A. Write a three-part agenda for your next one-on-one.

B. Priya asks, "So, how are things going?" Write a better answer than "Fine."

Listen next

Office Lab 20, The First One-on-One. Larissa's first one-on-one with Karen. Listen for "every second Tuesday" and "That's a win."

Em resumo: O one-on-one é seu: leve uma pauta em três partes, montada com as anotações do fim do dia, e pergunte o que é sucesso em 90 dias.

PART TWO

THE FIRST MONTH

From week four to week six, you stop being the new person and become part of the routine. This is when meetings, emails and chat start to shape the team's picture of you. These 13 cases cover everyday communication.

CASE 14

The Stand-up in Three Sentences

The case

Lucas joined an e-commerce company in Toronto where the team held a stand-up every day at 9:15, standing, for fifteen minutes. The first time it was his turn, he spoke for three minutes: the project background, every task from the day before, his meetings, a technical explanation of a bug.

The manager thanked him and said, "Let's take the details offline." The next three colleagues spoke for 30 seconds each. The stand-up finished on time, and Lucas realized he had used a quarter of it.

What was going on

A stand-up isn't a report. It's a quick sync, so everyone knows what the others are doing and who needs help. The informal rule is 30 to 60 seconds per person.

The almost universal format has three parts:

1. **Yesterday:** what you finished.
2. **Today:** what you'll do.
3. **Blockers:** anything stopping you.

Details go to a separate conversation with whoever needs them. Speaking clearly and briefly at the stand-up builds, every day, a small reputation for organization.

A tip: prepare your three sentences at the end of the previous day, with your after-hours notes. The next morning, you arrive early and already know what you'll say.

English models

- "Yesterday I finished the checkout bug fix."
- "Today I'm working on the payment tests."
- "No blockers." / "One blocker: I'm waiting on access to the staging server."
- "Happy to go into more detail after the stand-up if anyone needs it."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
stand-up	reunião diária rápida (em pé)
a blocker	um impedimento
to wrap up	encerrar
to ping someone	mandar uma mensagem rápida
to take it offline	conversar sobre isso depois, à parte

Practice

A. Turn this into three stand-up sentences:

> *Yesterday morning I was in a meeting, and in the afternoon I finished the sales report. Today I'm starting the customer analysis, but I still don't have the data from marketing.*

B. How long should your stand-up update be?

Listen next

Office Lab 10, The Morning Stand-up. Larissa's first stand-up. Listen for "blocker," "ping" and "wrap up."

Em resumo: Na stand-up, fale em três frases (ontem, hoje, bloqueios) e deixe os detalhes para depois.

CASE 15

The Meeting Invite

The case

In her first month at an insurance company in Calgary, Carolina accepted every meeting invite she received. Within three weeks, she had 22 hours of meetings a week and almost no time for actual work. In some meetings, she didn't know why she was there.

A colleague said, "You know half of those are optional, right?" Carolina hadn't noticed the word "Optional" next to her name on the invites.

What was going on

A Canadian meeting invite carries a lot of information, and it's worth reading before you accept:

- **Required / Optional:** if you're optional, you can choose not to go. Often the organizer just wants you to be informed.
- **Agenda:** the topics. If there's no agenda, it's normal to ask.
- **Hard stop:** a time when someone must leave, with no exceptions.

Accepting or declining with a short note is professional. Declining with nothing can seem cold.

When you do go, arrive or join two minutes early. It's the same rule as the first day: Canadian punctuality means starting on time, not arriving on time.

English models

Asking about the meeting:

- "Is there an agenda for this one? I want to make sure I come prepared."
- "Do you need me there, or should I just catch up on the notes?"

Declining politely:

- "I won't be able to make this one, but please send me the notes."

Flagging a time limit:

- "Just a heads-up, I have a hard stop at 3."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
an invite	um convite (de reunião)

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
optional / required	opcional / obrigatório
a hard stop	um horário-limite inegociável
a parking lot	lista de assuntos para depois
to make it	conseguir ir

Practice

A. You've been invited as "Optional" to a meeting unrelated to your work. Write your reply.

B. What does "I have a hard stop at 3" mean?

Listen next

Office Lab 11, The Meeting Invite. Rodrigo walks Larissa through a meeting invite. Listen for "optional," "parking lot" and "hard stop."

Em resumo: Leia o convite antes de aceitar: "optional" é opcional mesmo, e quando você for, entre dois minutos antes.

CASE 16

Getting into the Conversation

The case

Felipe was a project manager with fifteen years of experience in Porto Alegre. In meetings at his new company in Vancouver, he waited for a pause before speaking, as he did in Brazil when he wanted to be respectful. The pause never came. The conversation jumped from topic to topic, and by the time he was ready to speak, the subject had changed.

At his 30-day check-in, the director said, "You clearly know your stuff. I just wish we heard more from you in meetings."

What was going on

In many Canadian meetings, nobody will give you the floor. You're expected to join the conversation politely. Waiting for the perfect pause feels respectful to you, but to the team it looks like you have no opinion.

Three techniques that work:

1. **Prepare one comment before the meeting.** Read the agenda and choose one point where you can contribute.
2. **Speak in the first ten minutes.** The longer you wait, the harder it gets.
3. **Use an entry phrase.** It signals you're about to speak and gives others a second to make room.

One idea said out loud in a meeting does more for your reputation than ten good ideas kept silent.

English models

To join the conversation:

- "Can I jump in here?"
- "Just to build on what Sarah said..."
- "Sorry, can I add something before we move on?"

When someone interrupts you:

- "Sorry, let me just finish this thought."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to jump in	entrar na conversa
to build on	complementar (a ideia de alguém)
to move on	passar para o próximo assunto
to know your stuff	conhecer bem o assunto
I've been there	já passei por isso

Practice

A. Write a sentence to join the conversation and build on an idea from a colleague named Ben.

B. Why can waiting for the perfect pause hurt your reputation in Canada?

Listen next

Office Lab 15, Speaking Up. After a big client meeting, Larissa learns three phrases for speaking up.

Em resumo: Ninguém vai dar a palavra a você: prepare um comentário, fale nos primeiros dez minutos e use uma frase de entrada.

CASE 17

Disagreeing Without Causing Trouble

The case

Vanessa was a data analyst at a telecom company in Montreal. In a meeting, her colleague Jason presented a sales forecast. Vanessa spotted the error immediately and said, "No, that's wrong. You're using last year's numbers."

She was right. But the room went quiet. Jason turned red. After the meeting, her manager called her aside and said calmly, "You were right about the numbers. But you might want to think about how it landed."

What was going on

In Canada, disagreement is welcome. The problem is the form. Blunt phrases like "That's wrong" or "No" sound much stronger in Canadian English than "Não, está errado" would sound between Brazilian colleagues.

The formula for disagreeing respectfully:

1. **Acknowledge** the other person's point.
2. **Give your view** with data, not judgment.
3. **Turn it into a question** where you can.

Vanessa could have said: "Thanks, Jason. I might be wrong, but are these last year's numbers? I think the Q3 figures came out last week." The information is the same. The reputation that stays is very different: someone who improves the team's work without embarrassing anyone.

English models

- "I see where you're coming from, but..."
- "Can I push back a little on that?"
- "I might be wrong, but I think..."
- "Have we thought about...?"
- "That's a fair point. My concern is..."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to push back	contestar, discordar
I see where you're coming from	entendo o seu ponto
a fair point	um argumento válido
how it landed	como foi recebido
a concern	uma preocupação

Practice

A. Rewrite Vanessa's sentence using the three-step formula:

> *No, that's wrong. You're using last year's numbers.*

B. When the manager says, "You might want to think about how it landed," is it an optional suggestion or important feedback?

Listen next

Office Lab 12, Disagreeing Politely. A meeting where Larissa disagrees respectfully. Listen for "I see where you're coming from, but" and "Can I push back a little?"

Em resumo: Discordar é bem-vindo; o que pesa é a forma: reconheça o ponto do outro, use dados e transforme em pergunta.

CASE 18

“Let’s Take This Offline”

The case

In a ten-person meeting at an energy company in Calgary, Eduardo and a colleague started debating a technical detail of the budget. It went on for five minutes. The other eight people looked at their phones.

The manager stepped in: “Great discussion. Let’s take this offline, you two.” Eduardo was upset. He felt he’d been cut off in front of everyone. After the meeting, he went back to his desk and didn’t follow up with his colleague. The issue was never resolved.

What was going on

“Let’s take this offline” isn’t a reprimand. It means: this matters, but not to everyone in this room. Continue later, in a smaller group.

Eduardo’s mistake wasn’t the debate. It was not continuing it afterwards. When a manager says “take it offline,” they expect someone to actually set up that conversation. If you do, you show you read the signal correctly and that you get things done. If you don’t, the topic dies, and someone will remember who started it.

Practical rule: whenever you hear “let’s take this offline” about your topic, message your colleague the same day.

English models

In the meeting:

- “Happy to take this offline. Mark, can we grab ten minutes after this?”

After the meeting:

- "Hi Mark, following up on the budget question from this morning. Are you free for 15 minutes tomorrow to talk it through?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to take something offline	continuar o assunto depois, à parte
to talk it through	conversar até chegar a um acordo
to follow up	dar continuidade
I get that, but...	entendo, mas...

Practice

A. What does "Let's take this offline" mean? Is it criticism?

B. Write the message Eduardo should have sent his colleague after the meeting.

Listen next

Office Lab 13, Let's Take This Offline. A meeting and the conversation right after it. Listen for "talk it through" and "I get that, but."

Em resumo: "Let's take this offline" não é bronca: é um pedido para continuar depois; mande a mensagem ao colega no mesmo dia.

CASE 19

Action Items and the Follow-up

The case

Priscila took part in a great planning meeting at a healthcare company in Ottawa. Everyone agreed to launch a patient survey. Two weeks later, at the next meeting, the manager asked, “So, where are we on the survey?” Silence. Nobody had done anything, because nobody knew who was responsible.

Priscila remembered that she had offered to write the questions. But she hadn’t written it down, and nobody had sent a summary.

What was going on

A well-run Canadian meeting ends with action items: who does what, by when. When they aren’t said out loud or recorded in an email, good intentions disappear.

Here is one of the easiest ways to build a reputation in your first month: **offer to send the meeting notes.** It’s a small job nobody wants, and it makes you visible, organized and useful to everyone.

A simple follow-up email:

1. One line of thanks.
2. The decisions made.
3. The action items, with names and deadlines.
4. The next step or next meeting.

Send it the same day. Your after-hours notes already have everything you need.

English models

At the end of the meeting:

- "Before we wrap up, can we go over the action items?"
- "I'm happy to send out the notes."

The email:

> *Hi team,*
>
> *Thanks for a great discussion today. Just to recap:*
>
> - Priscila: draft the survey questions by Friday.
> - Tom: confirm the budget by Wednesday at the latest.
> - We'll circle back on the launch date next week.
>
> *Let me know if I missed anything.*
>
> *Thanks, Priscila*

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
action items	tarefas combinadas na reunião
to recap	resumir
at the latest	no máximo, o mais tardar
to circle back	voltar ao assunto depois
to send out	enviar (para o grupo)
to skim	ler rapidamente

Practice

A. Write a short follow-up email for a meeting where: Ana will review the contract by Tuesday; you will update the spreadsheet by Friday; the next meeting is on the 15th.

B. Why does offering to send the notes help your reputation?

Listen next

Office Lab 14, Action Items, and Office Lab 19, Sending the Meeting Notes. Listen for why "Hi team" works better than "Dear team."

Em resumo: Toda reunião precisa terminar com quem faz o quê e até quando; ofereça-se para mandar as notas no mesmo dia.

CASE 20

You're on Mute

The case

Leandro worked from home two days a week at a software company in Waterloo. On his first important video call, he joined with his camera off and his dog barking in the background. When the manager asked him a question, he answered for fifteen seconds before someone said, "Leandro, you're on mute."

He repeated his answer. Then his connection dropped. When he came back, the meeting had moved on.

What was going on

In hybrid work, a video call is often the only place your team sees you. In your first 90 days, every call is part of your reputation, just like an in-person meeting.

The practical rules:

- **Join two minutes early.** Test your audio and camera before it starts.
- **Camera on** in your first weeks, unless the whole team keeps theirs off.
- **Stay on mute** when you're not speaking. Unmute before you answer.
- **Say numbers digit by digit** on a bad connection: "one-four" for 14.
- **Use the chat** for links and to ask to speak in large meetings.

English models

When the connection fails:

- "Sorry, you're breaking up. Could you say that again?"
- "I think your video froze."
- "I lost you for a second. Could you repeat the last part?"

When you were on mute:

- "Sorry, I was on mute! As I was saying..."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
you're on mute	você está no mudo
you're breaking up	sua voz está cortando
it froze	travou (a imagem)

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
go ahead	pode falar
put it in the chat	coloque no chat

Practice

A. Your colleague's voice keeps cutting out. What do you say?

B. List three things to do before joining an important video call.

Listen next

Office Lab 39, You're Breaking Up, and Office Lab 40, You're on Mute. Listen for how Paul says numbers digit by digit.

Em resumo: Na videochamada, entre dois minutos antes, câmera ligada no começo, microfone no mudo e números ditos dígito por dígito.

CASE 21

Your Time or Mine?

The case

Daniela worked in Vancouver for a company with offices in Toronto and Halifax. In her second week, she set up a meeting with the Toronto team "at 9 a.m." She meant 9 a.m. Vancouver time. The Toronto team understood 9 a.m. Toronto time: 6 a.m. for her.

At 6:05, Daniela's phone buzzed with a message: "Are you joining?"

What was going on

Canada has six time zones. Toronto is three hours ahead of Vancouver; Halifax is four. In companies with teams in several cities, a time without a time zone is a trap.

The rule is simple: **always write the time zone.** In invites, emails and messages, give both times when two cities are involved. And if someone suggests a time without a zone, ask.

Small details like this show you think about others. It's one more layer of a reputation for reliability.

English models

- "Does 10 a.m. Pacific, 1 p.m. Eastern work for everyone?"
- "Just to confirm, is that your time or my time?"
- "I'm on Pacific time, so I'm three hours behind you."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
time zone	fuso horário
Pacific / Eastern / Atlantic time	horário do Pacífico / do Leste / do Atlântico
to be three hours ahead / behind	estar três horas à frente / atrás
does that work for you?	esse horário funciona para você?

Practice

A. You're in Vancouver and want to meet a Toronto team at 11 a.m. your time. Write the proposal with both times.

B. A colleague in Halifax writes, "Can we talk at 2?" What do you reply?

Listen next

Office Lab 41, Time Zones. A call between two cities. Listen for "Two o'clock your time, or my time?"

Em resumo: O Canadá tem seis fusos; escreva sempre o fuso e, com duas cidades, os dois horários.

CASE 22

The Tone of a Canadian Email

The case

Henrique had been a corporate lawyer in Rio and joined a company in Toronto as a compliance analyst. His first email to a director began: "Dear Mr. Thompson, I hereby kindly request that you send the aforementioned documents at your earliest convenience."

The director replied, "Hi Henrique, sure thing. Attached. – Dave."

The next week, annoyed by a delay, Henrique wrote to a colleague: "Send me the file today." The colleague sent it, but from then on was cooler with him.

What was going on

Canadian work email is short, friendly and to the point. Henrique got it wrong twice, in opposite directions: first too formal, then too blunt. The *juridiquês* that sounds professional in Brazil sounds stiff here, and a bare command sounds rude.

The Canadian balance:

- **Greeting:** "Hi Dave," almost always. "Dear" is too formal except in official letters.

- **First line:** the reason for the email.
- **Requests:** always softened. “Could you…?”, “Would you mind…?”
- **Length:** short. If you have to scroll, a conversation might be better.
- **Closing:** “Thanks,”, “Best,”, “Cheers,”.
- **Reply time:** within 24 hours, even if only to say when you’ll answer properly.

Every email you send is on record. In your first months, it’s the most permanent form of reputation there is.

English models

Asking for something:

> *Hi Dave,*
>
> *Could you send me the signed vendor agreements when you get a chance? I need them for Thursday’s audit.*
>
> *Thanks, Henrique*

Replying before you have the answer:

- “Thanks for this. I’ll look into it and get back to you by Friday.”

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
when you get a chance	quando puder
attached	em anexo
sure thing	claro, sem problema
to get back to someone	retornar, responder depois

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to look into	verificar, analisar

Practice

A. Rewrite Henrique's two sentences in a Canadian tone:

1. "I hereby kindly request that you send the aforementioned documents at your earliest convenience."
2. "Send me the file today."

B. Which greeting is more common in a Canadian work email: "Dear Dave," or "Hi Dave,"?

Listen next

Office Lab 19, Sending the Meeting Notes. Karen comments on Larissa's email. Listen for "skim" and why "Dear team" sounds too formal.

Em resumo: Email canadense é curto, simpático e direto: "Hi" + nome, o motivo na primeira linha e pedidos sempre suavizados.

CASE 23

Slack and Teams: Quick Isn't Curt

The case

Natália worked at a startup in Montreal where almost everything happened on Slack. When she needed something, she sent a colleague "Hi" and waited for a reply before writing her question. Sometimes the answer came 40 minutes later: "Hi! What's up?" Only then did Natália ask.

When others asked her for things, she replied "ok" or just "k." One colleague asked another, "Is Natália upset with me? She's always so short."

What was going on

Work chat has its own etiquette. Two rules tripped Natália up:

- **Don't send just "Hi" and wait.** Put the greeting and the whole question in one message. That way the other person can answer when they're free, without losing time.
- **"Ok" on its own can sound cold.** In text, without a tone of voice, one-word replies read as irritation. "Sounds good, thanks!" or a thumbs-up emoji fixes it. In Brazil a quick "ok" between colleagues is neutral; here it can sound like a *cara fechada*.

Other useful rules:

- Use your status ("In a meeting," "Away") so the team knows when you're available.
- Reply within a few hours, even if it's only "On it, will get back to you this afternoon."
- Avoid sending messages after hours unless it's urgent. If you need to, schedule them.
- Never write IN CAPITALS. It reads as shouting.

In remote and hybrid work, chat is where the team lives with you. Your reputation there is built one message at a time.

English models

A complete request in one message:

- "Hi Alex! Quick question: do you know where the Q3 brand guidelines are saved? No rush."

Confirming:

- "Sounds good, thanks!"
- "On it."
- "Got it, will do."

When you need time:

- "I'm tied up this morning, but I'll get back to you after lunch."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
sounds good	combinado, ótimo
on it	já estou cuidando disso
got it	entendi
to be tied up	estar ocupado
no rush	sem pressa
to come across as	parecer, passar a impressão de

Practice

A. Rewrite this as a single chat message:

> *Hi*

> *(40 minutes later) Do you have the client's contact?*

B. A colleague asks, "Can you update the slide by 3?" Write a short reply that doesn't sound cold.

Listen next

There's no Office Lab script on chat. Reread Case 22 and compare: chat is even shorter than email, but the courtesy is the same.

Em resumo: No chat, mande a saudação e a pergunta juntas e troque o "ok" seco por "Sounds good, thanks!".

CASE 24

Reading an Email Between the Lines

The case

At 9 a.m., Vinícius received an email from a client: "Hi Vinícius, just circling back on the invoice I sent last week." He thought it was just a reminder and left it for later.

The next morning another one arrived: "Hi Vinícius, as per my previous email, could you please confirm receipt of the invoice?" This time his manager was copied.

What was going on

Canadian email rarely shows irritation directly. It appears in polite phrases that, once you know the code, are clear signals:

- **"Just circling back"** or **"Just following up"**: you haven't replied, and I noticed.

- **"As per my previous email"**: I already told you this; read it again.
- **"Just a friendly reminder"**: I'm getting impatient.
- **Someone new cc'd**, especially your manager: this has gone up a level.

When you see these signals, the right response is quick and calm: thank them, explain in one sentence and fix it. No long justifications, no defensiveness.

Replying before the first reminder arrives is always better. The emails you leave unanswered build a reputation too, just the wrong one.

English models

> *Hi Sarah,*
>
> *Thanks for following up, and sorry for the delay. I've received the invoice and it's been sent to accounts payable for processing this week.*
>
> *Best, Vinícius*

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to circle back	voltar ao assunto (às vezes: cobrar)
as per my previous email	conforme meu email anterior
to confirm receipt	confirmar o recebimento
to cc someone	colocar alguém em cópia
sorry for the delay	desculpe a demora

Practice

A. Put these in order, from least to most irritated: "As per my previous email" · "Just circling back" · "Hi, any update on this?"

B. Write a short, calm reply to a colleague who wrote, "Just a friendly reminder about the report."

Listen next

Office Lab 56, Reading Between the Lines of an Email. Larissa gets an email with signs of irritation and replies calmly.

Em resumo: "Just circling back" e "as per my previous email" são cobranças educadas; responda rápido, com calma e resolva.

CASE 25

"When You Get a Chance"

The case

In her sixth week at an engineering firm in Edmonton, Sabrina's manager sent her a message at 10 a.m.: "Could you pull together the project costs when you get a chance?" Sabrina read it as "no rush" and planned it for the following week.

At 4 p.m., her manager stopped by her desk. "How are those numbers coming along? I need them for a call with the client at 5."

What was going on

In Canadian English, urgency is rarely spelled out. "When you get a chance" can mean "no rush" or "today, please." It depends on the context, the person and the subject.

Some clues:

- **"At your earliest convenience"** almost always means as soon as possible.

- **"By EOD"** (end of day) means by the end of today.
- **"No rush"** is usually true, but it doesn't mean never.
- A request from your manager connected to a client is almost never "no rush."

When in doubt, the solution is simple: ask. Nobody finds it strange. And answering with a deadline you propose yourself makes you look organized.

Watch for the opposite too: questions that sound casual but ask for a commitment. "Do you think you could get this done by Friday?" isn't curiosity about your schedule. It's a request for a deadline. Your answer needs to be clear: yes, with a promise to flag any change, or a realistic alternative.

English models

Clarifying urgency:

- "Sure. Do you need this by a specific time?"
- "Happy to. Is end of day okay, or do you need it sooner?"
- "I can have it to you by 2. Does that work?"

Answering a commitment question:

- "Yes, I should be able to finish it by Friday. I'll let you know if anything changes."
- "I can get most of it done by Friday, but I'll need until Monday for the rest. Would that work?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
when you get a chance	quando puder (pode ser urgente!)

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
at your earliest convenience	o mais rápido possível
EOD (end of day)	até o fim do dia
to pull together	juntar, organizar
coming along	progredindo

Practice

A. Your manager writes, "Could you send me the slides when you get a chance?" Write a reply that clarifies the deadline.

B. What does "by EOD" mean?

C. A colleague asks, "Do you think you could get this done by Friday?" You can finish most of it, but not all. Write your answer.

Listen next

Office Lab 53, When You Get a Chance. Karen asks Larissa for something. Listen for how Larissa checks the deadline.

Em resumo: "When you get a chance" pode ser urgente e "could you get this done by Friday?" é um pedido de compromisso; na dúvida, pergunte o prazo.

CASE 26

Hybrid Work and Core Hours

The case

Paulo started at a tech company in Vancouver with a hybrid model: two days in the office, three at home. He chose Monday and Friday for the office, because those were the days with the least traffic.

After a month, he realized almost nobody from his team came in on Mondays and Fridays. He spent his office days alone. And on his home days, he sometimes went offline at 3 p.m. after starting at 7.

At his 30-day check-in, his manager asked carefully, "How are you finding the hybrid setup? We don't see you much."

What was going on

Hybrid flexibility is real, but two rules are almost never written down:

1. **Core hours:** a window when everyone is expected to be available, often between 10 a.m. and 3 or 4 p.m. Being offline in that window, even if you started early, makes you seem to disappear.
2. **The right office days:** the value of going in is being with your team. Going on the days they aren't there meets the rule but gains you nothing.

During probation, go in on the days your team goes in and, if you can, a little more than the minimum. Your manager will probably say you don't have to. They're right. But you're building a reputation, and it builds faster when people see you.

English models

- "Which days does the team usually come in?"
- "What are our core hours?"
- "I'm going to step away for 20 minutes. Back at 2."
- "I'm planning to come in three days a week during my first few months, so I can get to know everyone."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
hybrid	híbrido (casa e escritório)
core hours	horário em que todos devem estar disponíveis
to come in	ir ao escritório
to step away	se ausentar por pouco tempo
setup	arranjo, configuração

Practice

A. Write the question you would ask your team in your first week to find out which days to come in.

B. Your manager says, "We don't see you much." Is that a neutral comment or feedback? What would you do?

Listen next

Office Lab 23, Working from Home. Karen and Larissa talk about the hybrid model. Listen for "core hours" and "step away."

Em resumo: No híbrido, respeite as core hours e vá ao escritório nos dias em que a equipe vai; no probation, se puder, vá um pouco mais.

PART THREE

GAINING GROUND

From week seven to week ten, your team knows who you are. Now the question changes: are you growing? These 13 cases cover your relationship with your manager, feedback in every direction, and how to make your work visible.

CASE 27

Bring the Agenda to Your One-on-One

The case

Letícia was in her fourth one-on-one with her manager at an insurance company in Halifax. The conversations were pleasant but always the same: a little small talk, one question about the project, "Anything else?" and done. She had no idea whether she was doing well.

An experienced colleague, Rachel, showed her own method: a document shared with the manager, with an agenda for each week, a list of "wins" and one fixed question at the end of every meeting.

What was going on

By your third month, the one-on-one becomes your main tool for tracking your probation, but only if you lead it. A busy manager will rarely offer, on their own, an assessment of how you're doing.

Rachel's method has three parts:

1. **A shared document** with the agenda for every one-on-one. Your manager sees it in advance, and decisions are recorded.
2. **A list of wins**, with numbers where possible. It's your memory of results for the 90-day conversation.
3. **One fixed question at the end:** "How am I tracking?" Every week. That way you're never surprised.

Your after-hours notes feed this document. Ten minutes a day become a ready agenda every week, and a reputation as someone who takes their career seriously.

English models

- "I've added a few things to our doc. Can we start with the vendor issue?"
- "A quick win from this week: I cut the claims backlog from 120 to 85."
- "Before we wrap up: how am I tracking so far?"
- "Is there anything you'd like to see more of, or less of?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
a win	uma conquista, um resultado positivo
how am I tracking?	como estou indo?
a backlog	trabalho acumulado
a running doc	documento contínuo, sempre atualizado
to see more of	ver mais de

Practice

A. Write two wins from your week, with numbers if possible.

B. What is the fixed question Rachel asks at the end of every one-on-one? Why is it useful?

Listen next

Office Lab 20, The First One-on-One. Listen again, this time to how Karen asks "So, how are things going so far?" and how Larissa could have answered with an agenda.

Em resumo: Conduza o seu one-on-one com um documento compartilhado, uma lista de wins e a pergunta fixa "How am I tracking?".

CASE 28

Too Many Priorities

The case

Caio was the most helpful analyst on his team at a retail company in Toronto. Whenever someone asked for help, he said yes. Eight weeks in, he had six projects at once, stayed until 8 p.m., and still missed two deadlines.

When his manager asked what was going on, he said, "I'm fine, I can handle it." A week later, he missed a third.

What was going on

In Brazil, saying yes to everything can be seen as dedication. In Canada it is too, right up until quality drops. From that moment, the reputation flips from "always available" to "can't manage his own workload."

Saying no directly to your manager is hard. The Canadian solution is different: **ask your manager to help you prioritize.** You show the list, explain what fits in the time you have, and let them decide. You don't refuse anything. You organize.

When the request comes from a colleague, there's a model for saying no kindly: acknowledge, explain, offer an alternative.

English models

With your manager:

- "I want to flag that I'm at capacity. Here's what's on my plate. Can you help me prioritize?"
- "If I take this on, the client report will slip to next week. Which one is more important?"

With a colleague:

- "I'd love to help, but I'm swamped until Friday. Could it wait until Monday?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
what's on your plate?	o que você tem para fazer agora?
at capacity	no limite
swamped	atolado de trabalho
overwhelmed	sobrecarregado
to slip	atrasar
to take on	assumir (uma tarefa)

Practice

A. You have three projects and your manager asks for a fourth. Write what you would say to ask for help prioritizing.

B. Why did "I'm fine, I can handle it" hurt Caio's reputation?

Listen next

Office Lab 21, Too Many Priorities. Karen teaches Larissa to say no politely. Listen for "What's on your plate?" and "I'd love to help, but..."

Em resumo: Não diga sim a tudo; mostre a sua lista ao manager e peça ajuda para priorizar, antes que a qualidade caia.

CASE 29

"Make It Pop"

The case

Mônica's director at an advertising agency in Vancouver looked at her presentation and said, "Looks good. Can you keep it high-level and make it pop a bit more?"

Mônica didn't want to seem like she hadn't understood. She spent the night changing colours, fonts and animations. The next day, the director sighed. "Oh, I meant fewer slides and a stronger opening."

What was going on

Vague instructions happen in every country. The difference is the cost of not asking. In Canada, asking for clarification isn't a sign of weak English or inexperience. It's a sign of professionalism, because it prevents rework.

"Make it pop" can mean more visual, more impact, more clarity or a stronger opening. "High-level" means the main ideas only, without detail. The only way to know exactly what someone wants is to ask, ideally for an example.

A ten-second clarifying question saves a whole night and builds a reputation as someone who understands the request before starting.

English models

- "Sorry, can I ask what you mean exactly by 'pop'?"
- "Do you have an example of what you're picturing?"
- "Just so I'm clear: fewer slides, or a different design?"
- "When you say high-level, how many slides are you thinking?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
high-level	só as ideias principais
to make it pop	deixar mais impactante
to picture	imaginar, visualizar
just so I'm clear	só para eu ter certeza
rework	retrabalho

Practice

A. Your manager says, "Can you make this report a bit tighter?" Write a clarifying question.

B. Why did Mônica lose a night of work?

Listen next

Office Lab 25, Make It Pop. Karen gives a vague request and Larissa asks for clarification. Listen for "Sorry, can I ask what you mean exactly?"

Em resumo: Pedido vago? Pergunte em dez segundos, de preferência pedindo um exemplo; no Canadá isso é profissionalismo, não fraqueza.

CASE 30

"Just Checking In" Isn't a Warning

The case

Igor was working on a financial report at a construction company in Calgary. On Tuesday, his manager messaged him: "Hey Igor, just checking in. How's the report coming along?"

Igor spent the afternoon anxious. He assumed she distrusted his work, or that he was behind without knowing it. He replied with a long email full of justifications.

His manager answered, "Oh, no worries at all! I was just curious. Sounds great."

What was going on

"Just checking in" is one of the most common phrases in a Canadian office, and it almost always means exactly what it says: a friendly question about progress. It doesn't mean there's a problem. It isn't a *cobrança*.

The right answer is short: where things stand, the next step and, if there is one, a blocker. No justifications.

Better still: send updates before your manager asks. If they never need to say "just checking in," you've earned one of the best reputations there is: someone who keeps everyone informed.

English models

Replying:

- "It's coming along well! About 70% done, and I'm on track for Thursday."
- "Good, thanks. I'm waiting on the Q3 numbers from finance, but otherwise on track."

Getting ahead of the question:

- "Quick update: the report is about halfway done. I'll send a draft on Wednesday."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
just checking in	só queria saber como está
coming along	progredindo
on track	dentro do prazo
out of the blue	do nada, sem aviso
halfway done	pela metade

Practice

A. Your manager writes, "Just checking in, how's the presentation going?" Write a short reply.

B. True or false: "Just checking in" usually means your manager is worried about your work.

Listen next

Office Lab 24, Just Checking In. A video call with Karen. Listen for "coming along" and "out of the blue."

Em resumo: "Just checking in" é só uma pergunta amigável; responda curto e, melhor ainda, mande atualizações antes que perguntem.

CASE 31

Taking a Compliment

The case

In her eighth week at a software company in Ottawa, Fabiana ran a client workshop that was a big success. At the team meeting, the director said, "Fabiana, great job on the workshop. The client feedback was excellent."

Fabiana answered quickly: "Oh, it was nothing. The team did everything." The director smiled, but looked a little awkward. Later, a colleague told her, "You should take the credit. That's not nothing."

What was going on

Many Brazilians grew up learning that accepting a compliment looks arrogant. In Canada, refusing one can seem strange: as if you're correcting the person who praised you, or as if you don't believe in your own work.

The Canadian reply has two parts:

1. **Say thank you** and accept it: "Thank you, I'm really happy with how it went."
2. **Give specific credit** to anyone who helped: "Mark's slides made a big difference."

"The team did everything" erases you. "Mark's slides made a big difference" shows you led and that you recognize others. Both build reputation.

English models

- "Thank you, I really appreciate that."
- "Thanks! I'm really happy with how it went."
- "Thank you. And Mark's slides made a big difference."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to take credit	assumir o mérito
to give credit	dar o mérito a alguém
that's not nothing	isso não é pouca coisa
I appreciate that	agradeço muito
to downplay	minimizar

Practice

A. Your manager says, "Great presentation today!" Write a two-part reply.

B. Why can "Oh, it was nothing" hurt your reputation?

Listen next

Office Lab 29, Taking a Compliment. Megan praises Larissa. Practise the model reply: "Thank you, I'm really happy with how it went."

Em resumo: Elogio se aceita com um obrigado e se divide com crédito específico; "não foi nada" apaga você.

CASE 32

Taking Criticism

The case

Ricardo left his one-on-one at a logistics company in Mississauga feeling great. His manager had said: "Your analysis on the routes was great. One small thing I'd love to see you work on is sharing drafts earlier, so we can give input. But overall, I'm really pleased with how you're settling in."

Ricardo told his wife the meeting had gone really well. The next week, he delivered another report without sharing a draft first. His manager was visibly frustrated.

What was going on

Canadian feedback often comes as a sandwich: praise, a point to improve, more praise. The most common mistake is hearing only the bread. **The middle sentence is the message.**

Phrases that tell you criticism is coming:

- "One small thing I'd love to see you work on..."
- "Don't take this the wrong way, but..."
- "Something to think about..."

- "It would be great if..."

"Small" doesn't mean small. It means your manager is being kind.

The response that builds reputation has three steps: thank them, ask a question to understand better, and say what you'll do. Then, and this is the most important part, **show the change the following week**, visibly. A Canadian manager remembers how you reacted to feedback far longer than the mistake itself.

English models

- "Thanks, that's really helpful."
- "Could you give me an example, so I know what to look out for?"
- "Got it. Next time I'll send you a draft by Wednesday."

The following week:

- "Here's an early draft of the report. Any input before I go further?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
feedback	retorno, avaliação
input	contribuição, opinião
don't take this the wrong way	não leve a mal
to work on	trabalhar para melhorar
to look out for	prestar atenção em

Practice

A. What is the real message here? "Great work this week. One small thing: it would be great if you could reply to client emails a bit faster. Keep it up!"

B. Write your three-step response to that feedback.

Listen next

Office Lab 30, A Bit of Feedback. Karen gives Larissa feedback. Listen for the structure: praise, one clear point, a positive ending.

Em resumo: No feedback em sanduíche, a frase do meio é a mensagem; agradeça, pergunte e mostre a mudança na semana seguinte.

CASE 33

The Soft No

The case

In a meeting at an energy company in Calgary, Elaine proposed a new process for the monthly reports. The director said, "That's an interesting idea. Let's keep it in mind," and moved on to the next item.

Elaine left excited. She spent the week preparing a detailed plan. When she showed it to the director, he said, "Oh, I think we're going to stick with what we have for now."

The same week, she showed a draft to a colleague, who said, "It's a good start." Elaine took it to mean it was nearly finished.

What was going on

In Canada, “no” is rarely said with that word. It comes in polite phrases that newcomers often hear as “yes” or “almost there.” This is the soft no.

WHAT PEOPLE SAY	WHAT IT OFTEN MEANS
“That’s an interesting idea.”	Not now.
“Let’s keep it in mind.”	Probably not.
“It’s a good start.”	It needs a lot more work.
“Have you thought about…?”	Do this.
“I’d rather not.”	No.
“Let’s table this.”	Let’s discuss it later.

The most reliable clue is what happens next. If the person changes the subject quickly, it’s probably a no. If they ask questions and set a next step, the interest is real.

When in doubt, ask a question that requires a concrete answer. It saves weeks of wasted work and shows maturity, which is reputation too.

English models

- “What would you change first?”
- “Would it be worth putting together a short proposal, or is now not the right time?”
- “What would need to happen for this to move forward?”

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
a soft no	um não disfarçado

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to keep in mind	ter em mente
to stick with	manter, continuar com
to table	adiar a discussão (atenção: no Canadá também pode significar apresentar para discussão; na dúvida, pergunte)
to move forward	avançar

Practice

A. What do these probably mean? (1) "It's a good start." (2) "That's an interesting idea," followed by a quick change of subject.

B. Write a question Elaine could have asked the director to find out whether her idea had a real chance.

Listen next

Office Lab 31, What "A Good Start" Means, and Office Lab 49, That's an Interesting Idea. Listen for what happens right after each phrase.

Em resumo: No Canadá, o "não" vem disfarçado: "interesting idea" e "good start" raramente são um sim; observe o que acontece depois e pergunte.

CASE 34

Ask for Feedback Before It Arrives

The case

Murilo was in his ninth week at a tech company in Toronto, waiting for his 90-day review to find out how he was doing. A Canadian colleague, Hannah,

who had started at the same time, asked for feedback after every deliverable: "What's one thing I could have done better on this?"

By review time, Hannah had already fixed three points the manager raised. Murilo heard the same points for the first time.

What was going on

Waiting for formal feedback is risky. By the time it arrives, it's too late to change the impression. In Canada, asking for feedback is seen as a sign of maturity and a desire to grow.

But "Do you have any feedback for me?" rarely works. The polite answer is almost always "No, you're doing great!" The secret is to ask **specific questions**, which are easy to answer:

- About a concrete deliverable, right after it's done.
- Asking for one thing only.
- Asking what to improve, not whether it was good.

And when you get the feedback, apply it and show that you did. Each cycle like this is another brick in your reputation.

English models

- "What's one thing I could have done better on this presentation?"
- "If you were doing this report, what would you change?"
- "Is there anything I should start, stop or keep doing?"
- "I worked on sharing drafts earlier this week, like you suggested. How did that work on your end?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to ask for feedback	pedir retorno
on your end	do seu lado
to get back to you	responder depois
in a heartbeat	sem pensar duas vezes
you asked for it	você pediu (antes de uma resposta honesta)

Practice

A. Turn "Do you have any feedback for me?" into a specific question about a report you delivered yesterday.

B. Why does the general question rarely work?

Listen next

Office Lab 32, Asking for Feedback. Larissa asks a colleague for feedback. Listen for "You asked for it" and "in a heartbeat."

Em resumo: Não espere a avaliação formal: depois de cada entrega, pergunte "What's one thing I could have done better?" e aplique a resposta.

CASE 35

"You Might Want To..."

The case

Bianca sent an important email to a client at a consulting firm in Vancouver. Her manager commented afterwards: "Nice email. You might want to cc the director on client emails like that."

Bianca took it as an optional suggestion. The following week, she emailed the client again, without copying the director. Her manager said, more seriously now, "I mentioned this last week."

What was going on

In Canadian English, many instructions are phrased as suggestions. To Brazilian ears they sound optional. They almost never are.

WHAT PEOPLE SAY	WHAT IT MEANS
"You might want to..."	Please do this.
"Maybe think about..."	Do this.
"It might be worth..."	Do this.
"Something to consider..."	Consider it seriously.

Real options usually sound like this: "It's totally up to you" or "Either way works."

The practical rule: when your manager suggests something, treat it as an instruction. If the same suggestion has to be made twice, it's already a reputation problem: someone who doesn't listen.

English models

- "Good point, I'll make sure to do that from now on."
- "Thanks for the heads-up. Should I do that for all client emails, or just the big ones?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
you might want to	seria bom você (= faça isso)

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
it might be worth	valeria a pena (= faça isso)
it's totally up to you	a decisão é sua (opção real)
either way works	qualquer um serve
from now on	daqui para a frente

Practice

A. Which of these is a real option? (1) "You might want to double-check the numbers." (2) "It's totally up to you which template you use." (3) "It might be worth calling the client first."

B. Your manager says, "You might want to add a summary at the top." Write your reply.

Listen next

Office Lab 50, You Might Want To... A video call where Larissa receives an instruction disguised as a suggestion.

Em resumo: "You might want to" quase sempre quer dizer "faça isso"; trate a sugestão do manager como instrução.

CASE 36

When Your Manager Makes a Mistake

The case

The day before a board presentation at a healthcare company in Edmonton, Sérgio reviewed his manager's slides and found an error: the satisfaction rate showed 80%, but the data said 68%.

In Brazil, he might have said nothing. Correcting *a chefe* felt risky. But the presentation was the next day, in front of the board.

What was going on

In Canada, telling your manager about a mistake isn't disrespectful. Letting them present a wrong number to the board when you knew about it is far worse for your reputation, because it shows they can't count on you.

The secret is in how you do it:

1. **Privately**, never in front of others.
2. **Early**, with time to fix it.
3. **Gently**, leaving room for you to be wrong.
4. **With the data** in hand.

A Canadian manager almost always says thank you. And remembers. Protecting your manager from a mistake earns a reputation for trust that's worth more than any report.

English models

- "Do you have a minute before tomorrow? I might be wrong, but I think there's a typo on slide 6."
- "The survey shows sixty-eight percent, not eighty. Would you mind double-checking?"
- "I just wanted to flag it before the board meeting."

When your manager thanks you:

- "Not at all, happy to help."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
a typo	um erro de digitação
to flag	sinalizar, apontar
would you mind...?	você se importaria de...?
not at all	de jeito nenhum (= claro, com prazer)
the board	a diretoria, o conselho

Practice

A. Write how you would tell your manager that the date in an email they're about to send a client is wrong.

B. List the four rules for pointing out a manager's mistake.

Listen next

Office Lab 26, When the Manager Makes a Mistake. Larissa spots an error of Karen's. Listen for "eighty" and "sixty-eight," and the reply "Not at all."

Em resumo: Avisar o manager de um erro é lealdade, não desrespeito: em particular, cedo, com suavidade e com os dados.

CASE 37

Allies Outside Your Team

The case

Jéssica only talked to her own team at a manufacturing company in Waterloo. When she needed an urgent approval from finance, she sent a formal email and waited five days.

Her teammate Tyler asked for a similar approval the same week and got it in one afternoon. He explained: "I know Priya in finance. We chatted at the barbecue last month."

What was going on

In Canada, as in Brazil, things move faster between people who know each other. *Ter contatos* matters here too. The difference is that work relationships here are built in small, organized moments: the company barbecue, a 15-minute coffee, a cross-team project.

In your first 90 days, build relationships outside your own team too:

- **Go to company events,** even if they seem optional. For the company, they are. For your reputation, they aren't.
- **Ask for short coffees** with people in the teams you'll work with: "I'd love to understand how your team works."
- **Ask what they need from you,** not only what you need from them.

Your reputation doesn't stay inside your team. It travels across the company. The more people know it, the faster it works for you.

For a complete networking plan, see The Canadian Networking Code.

English models

- "Hi Priya, I'm new on the operations team. Would you be up for a quick coffee sometime next week? I'd love to understand how finance works with us."
- "What's the best way for my team to make your life easier?"
- "It was great chatting at the barbecue!"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
team building	integração de equipe
would you be up for...?	você toparia...?
to make someone's life easier	facilitar a vida de alguém
a coffee chat	um café para conversar
cross-functional	entre áreas

Practice

A. Write an invitation for a 15-minute coffee with someone in HR.

B. Why did Tyler get the approval so much faster?

Listen next

Office Lab 67, The Company Barbecue. The company barbecue in Stanley Park. Listen for "team building" and "way more fun."

Em resumo: Construa relações fora da sua equipe, em eventos e cafés curtos; a sua reputação viaja pela empresa.

CASE 38

Making Your Work Visible

The case

Otávio did far more than his role required at a tech company in Montreal. He automated a report that used to take four hours a week, trained two interns, and solved an old problem with a supplier. He told no one. He assumed good work would be noticed on its own.

At his 60-day check-in, his manager called him "solid, reliable" and mentioned none of it. She simply didn't know.

What was going on

In Canada, nobody expects you to show off. But nobody will discover what you did on their own, either. Managers are busy. Invisible work doesn't make it into the review.

A language detail helps a lot: Many Brazilians say *nós* about their own work, out of modesty. In English, "we" hides your contribution. Use "I" for what you did and "we" for what the team did, with numbers wherever possible.

Ways to make your work visible without seeming arrogant:

- **A short weekly update** to your manager, by email or in your one-on-one document.
- **Sharing useful results** in the team channel: "This saves us four hours a week."
- **Recording your wins** in your end-of-day notes, so you don't forget them at review time.

Reputation is what people know about you. If they don't know, it doesn't count.

English models

- "I automated the weekly report. It saves about four hours a week."
- "Quick share: the vendor issue is fixed. I worked with their account manager to update the contract."
- "I trained Emma and Jake on the new system this week."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
visible	visível
to show off	se exibir
solid, reliable	sólido, confiável
a self-assessment	uma autoavaliação
don't be too hard on yourself	não seja tão duro consigo mesmo

Practice

A. Rewrite using "I" and a number: "We improved the process a lot."

B. Write a three-line weekly update for your manager.

Listen next

Office Lab 35, Writing the Self-Assessment. Larissa writes her self-assessment. Listen for how her sentences change from "we" to "I," with numbers.

Em resumo: Ninguém vai descobrir sozinho o que você fez: use "I" em vez de "we", mostre números e registre os seus wins.

CASE 39

"We Should Grab Lunch Sometime"

The case

In the elevator of an office building in Toronto, a manager from another department told Luana, "Great to meet you! We should grab lunch sometime." Luana was pleased and waited for the invitation. It never came.

Two weeks later, she ran into him again. He said, "Hey! Things are crazy right now, but we should definitely catch up." Luana didn't know whether to insist or forget about it.

What was going on

"We should grab lunch sometime" is a friendly phrase, but it isn't always a plan. A real invitation has a day, a time or a place. "Things are crazy right now" is usually a polite way of saying "not soon." It's a bit like the Brazilian *"vamos marcar"*: warm, but not a date.

It doesn't mean the person doesn't like you. It's just part of small talk. The good news is that you can turn the vague phrase into a concrete plan, without pressure. If they accept a day and time, the interest is real. If not, you've lost nothing.

And in elevator conversations, keep the script short: "How are you?" usually just wants "Good, thanks! You?" and a "Have a good one!" on the way out.

English models

Turning it into a plan:

- "I'd love that! Are you free Thursday or Friday next week?"
- "Sounds great. How about the Thai place on King Street, Tuesday at 12?"

In the elevator:

- "Good, thanks! How about you?"
- "Have a good one!"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to grab lunch	almoçar (informal)
sometime	algum dia (vago)
things are crazy right now	estou muito ocupado agora
to catch up	colocar a conversa em dia
have a good one	tenha um bom dia (despedida)
could be worse	poderia ser pior

Practice

A. Someone says, “We should grab coffee sometime.” Write a reply that turns it into a plan.

B. What does “Things are crazy right now” usually mean?

Listen next

Office Lab 51, We Should Grab Lunch Sometime, and Office Lab 55, Elevator Small Talk.

Em resumo: “We should grab lunch sometime” é como o nosso “vamos marcar”; se você quiser, transforme em convite real, com dia e hora.

PART FOUR

PASSING PROBATION

From week eleven to week thirteen, the real problems show up: mistakes, deadlines, conflict. Nobody expects you never to make a mistake. They expect you to know what to do when you do. These last 13 cases take you to the 90-day conversation and beyond.

CASE 40

The Wrong Attachment

The case

In his eleventh week at a distributor in Calgary, Wagner sent a proposal to an important client. Five minutes later, he realized he had attached the spreadsheet with the company's internal margins.

His first impulse was to wait and hope the client wouldn't open it. His second was to send another email without telling anyone. Wagner froze for half an hour.

What was going on

Everyone makes mistakes. In Canada, what defines your reputation isn't the mistake; it's what you do in the first minutes after it. Hiding a mistake and being found out is far worse than the mistake itself.

The right sequence:

1. **Tell your manager immediately,** before they hear it from someone else.
2. **Take responsibility** in one sentence, without long excuses.
3. **Bring a proposed solution.**
4. **Say what you'll change.**

A Canadian manager usually reacts calmly to a mistake reported right away. What they don't easily forgive is finding out later. Those who report quickly earn the most important reputation of probation: *I can trust this person.*

English models

- "Do you have a minute? I made a mistake and I want you to hear it from me."
- "I sent the client the internal pricing sheet by accident. That's on me."
- "I can't recall it because it went outside the company, so I'd like to call them now and ask them to delete it. Does that sound okay?"
- "From now on, I'll double-check attachments before sending anything external."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to recall an email	tentar cancelar um email enviado (geralmente só funciona dentro da empresa)
please disregard	por favor, desconsidere
that's on me	a responsabilidade é minha
right away	imediatamente

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
by accident	sem querer
to double-check	conferir de novo

Practice

A. Put these in the right order: bring a solution · tell your manager · say what you'll change · take responsibility.

B. Write the first sentence you would say to your manager after a mistake.

Listen next

Office Lab 57, The Wrong Attachment. Larissa tells Karen she sent the wrong attachment. Listen for "recall the email" and "please disregard it."

Em resumo: Errou? Conte ao manager na hora, assuma em uma frase e chegue com uma solução; esconder o erro é o que destrói a confiança.

CASE 41

Fixing It with the Client

The case

Simone got the amount wrong on a client's invoice at a services company in Toronto. To make up for it, she wrote a three-paragraph apology explaining the new system, the lack of training and the busy week. She finished with, "I am deeply sorry for any inconvenience this may have caused."

The client replied, "No problem. Can you just send the corrected invoice?"

What was going on

In Canada, a professional apology is short: one clear sentence of apology, the correction and the next step. Long explanations look like excuses, and exaggerated apologies make the mistake seem bigger than it was.

The client doesn't want to know why it happened. They want to know it's fixed.

The structure:

1. **One sentence of apology.**
2. **The correction,** done or with a date.
3. **What changes** so it doesn't happen again, if relevant.
4. **Move on.**

Fixing it quickly and calmly builds, in the eyes of both the client and your manager, a reputation as someone reliable under pressure.

English models

> *Hello Mr. Chen,*
>
> *I'm sorry about the error on last week's invoice. The corrected version is attached, and I've added an extra check to our process so this doesn't happen again.*
>
> *Please let me know if you have any questions.*
>
> *Best, Simone*

If the client says they'd prefer to be told:

- "I'd much rather know" means: I strongly prefer to be informed.

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
an error	um erro
the corrected version	a versão corrigida
to make a big deal of	fazer tempestade em copo d'água
I'd much rather know	prefiro muito mais saber
to move on	seguir em frente

Practice

A. Rewrite in one sentence: "I am deeply sorry for any inconvenience this may have caused, it was a very busy week and the new system..."

B. Why can a long apology make things worse?

Listen next

Office Lab 58, Fixing It with the Client. Larissa calls the client. Listen for the one-sentence apology and how she moves on.

Em resumo: Pedido de desculpas profissional é uma frase, a correção e o próximo passo; o cliente quer saber que está resolvido, não por quê.

CASE 42

Asking for More Time

The case

Davi had a report due on Friday at an energy company in Edmonton. On Wednesday, he realized he wouldn't make it: he was missing data from

another department. He said nothing. He worked until 11 p.m. on Thursday and sent the report, incomplete, at 11:58 p.m. on Friday.

On Monday, his manager said, "I'd have been totally fine with Monday. I just needed to know."

What was going on

In Canada, deadlines matter, but surprises matter more. Most managers will accept a new deadline if they're told in advance. What damages your reputation is silence until the last minute, and rushed work.

The rule is to flag a deadline as soon as you know it's at risk, not after it has passed. And to come with a proposal:

1. **The reason,** in one sentence.
2. **A realistic new date.**
3. **What you can deliver earlier,** in the meantime.

Asking early for more time isn't weakness. It's management. It's exactly what your manager wants to see during probation.

English models

- "I wanted to give you a heads-up: I'm still waiting on the numbers from operations, so Friday is looking tight."
- "Would Monday work instead?"
- "In the meantime, I can send you the first two sections on Friday."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
tight	apertado

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
would Monday work instead?	segunda-feira funcionaria?
in the meantime	enquanto isso
to be at risk	estar em risco
to rush	fazer às pressas

Practice

A. Write the message Davi should have sent on Wednesday.

B. What are the three parts of a good request for more time?

Listen next

Office Lab 59, Asking for More Time. Larissa asks Karen for more time. Listen for "Would Monday work instead?" and "In the meantime."

Em resumo: Prazo em risco? Avise assim que souber, com o motivo, uma nova data e o que pode entregar antes; o problema é a surpresa, não o pedido.

CASE 43

The Colleague Who Overpromises

The case

In a client meeting at a software company in Vancouver, Helena's colleague Josh promised a new feature in two weeks. Helena, who would do the technical work, knew it needed at least six.

At the internal meeting the next day, she said in front of the whole team, "Josh, you can't promise things like that without asking me." Josh got defensive. The manager had to calm the conversation down.

What was going on

Helena was right about the timeline. But in Canada, raising a conflict with a colleague in front of everyone usually sounds like an attack, and the focus shifts from the problem to the fight.

The Canadian way to handle a problem with a colleague:

1. **Privately,** with the person first.
2. **With facts,** without judging their intent.
3. **With a clear request** for the future.
4. **With a solution** for the current problem.

People who handle conflict this way earn a reputation as mature, easy to work with even under tension.

English models

- "Hey Josh, do you have a few minutes? I wanted to talk about the timeline we gave the client."
- "From what I can see, the feature needs about six weeks, not two."
- "Going forward, could you check with me before we commit to dates?"
- "For now, how about we call the client together and give them an updated timeline?"

If the other person accepts responsibility, you may hear:

- "That's on me."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to overpromise	prometer demais

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to commit to	se comprometer com
going forward	daqui para a frente
defensive	na defensiva
timeline	cronograma

Practice

A. Rewrite Helena's sentence as a private conversation, using the four-step formula.

> *Josh, you can't promise things like that without asking me.*

B. Why did raising the problem in front of the team hurt Helena, even though she was right?

Listen next

Office Lab 60, When a Colleague Overpromises. Larissa talks to a colleague privately. Listen for "could you check with me before..." and "That's on me."

Em resumo: Problema com colega se resolve em particular, com fatos, um pedido claro e uma solução; em público, vira briga.

CASE 44

When Someone Takes the Credit

The case

In an informal chat with a colleague at a retail company in Montreal, Márcio suggested a way to reduce freight costs. Two weeks later, at the monthly

meeting, the colleague presented the idea as his own. The director praised him.

Márcio said nothing. He spent the month upset and started avoiding the colleague.

What was going on

This happens in every country, sometimes in bad faith, sometimes carelessly. Staying silent and resentful doesn't help your reputation. Accusing someone in public doesn't either.

The Canadian way is to reclaim the credit lightly and positively, without accusing anyone:

- **In the moment,** if possible, with a comment that links you to the idea: "Glad to see the idea I suggested getting traction."
- **Afterwards,** with the colleague, privately and calmly.
- **In the future,** putting your ideas in writing: a short email or a message in the team channel.

An idea in writing is much harder to take. It also keeps your contribution visible, as in Case 38.

English models

In the meeting:

- "I'm really glad the freight idea I suggested is getting traction. Happy to help develop it."

With the colleague:

- "Hey Eric, I noticed the freight idea came up in the meeting. I'd love to be involved, since we talked about it together."

For the future:

- "Following up on our chat, here's the idea I mentioned for cutting freight costs."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to take credit	levar o crédito
to get traction	ganhar força
keep it light	mantenha o tom leve
to be involved	participar
in writing	por escrito

Practice

A. Write a comment Márcio could have made in the meeting, without accusing anyone.

B. What can Márcio do next time to protect his ideas?

Listen next

Office Lab 61, When Someone Takes Credit. Larissa reclaims credit for an idea. Listen for "keep it light" and "the idea I suggested."

Em resumo: Se alguém levar o crédito, recupere com leveza e sem acusar; e, daqui para a frente, registre as suas ideias por escrito.

CASE 45

The System Is Down

The case

Isabela was about to run her first training session, for 20 people, at a healthcare company in Ottawa. At 8:55, five minutes before the start, the system she was going to demonstrate went down.

Isabela stood frozen at the front of the room, not knowing what to say. The participants started looking at their phones. In the end, she cancelled the session with no new date.

What was going on

In Canada, as anywhere, things go wrong. What people remember is how you reacted. A small crisis handled well can do more for your reputation than a month of quiet work.

Three habits that help:

1. **Have a plan B** for anything important: printed material, slides saved offline, an exercise that doesn't depend on the system.
2. **Communicate quickly and calmly:** what happened, what happens now, when there'll be news.
3. **Close with a clear next step:** a new date, a follow-up email.

Arriving early, the rule of this book, is also what gives you time for plan B. If Isabela had arrived at 8:30, she would have had her plan B ready and time to test it, so a failure at 8:55 would have been an inconvenience, not a crisis. Improvising won't save a training session; preparation will.

English models

- "Looks like the system is down. Let's switch to plan B."
- "While IT looks into it, I'll walk you through the process on paper."
- "The minute it's back up, we'll do the live demo."
- "I'll send everyone a new date for the hands-on part by end of day."

When someone helps you out:

- "You're a lifesaver!"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
the system is down	o sistema caiu
plan B	plano alternativo
back up (and running)	funcionando de novo
you're a lifesaver	você salvou o meu dia
hands-on	prático

Practice

A. The system goes down in the middle of a client meeting. Write two sentences to explain the problem and the next step.

B. What plan B would you prepare for an important presentation?

Listen next

Office Lab 62, The System Is Down. Larissa faces a system outage before a training session. Listen for "plan B" and "the minute the system is back up."

Em resumo: Toda apresentação importante precisa de um plano B, e chegar cedo é o que dá tempo de usá-lo.

CASE 46

Saying No Without Saying No

The case

In Cristina's twelfth week at a marketing company in Toronto, a manager from another department asked her to lead a new project: "You'd be perfect for this. Can you take it on?" She was already at her limit with her own projects.

Cristina had learned to ask her own manager to help her prioritize (Case 28). But this request came from outside her team, from someone she wanted a good relationship with. She didn't want to just say "no."

What was going on

In Canada, a flat "no" to a colleague can damage the relationship. A "yes" to everything damages your work. The way through is the soft no: acknowledge the request, explain your limit, and **offer something smaller** or later.

An alternative keeps the relationship positive and shows goodwill, without breaking what you've already promised. And when the request comes from another department, mention your manager: they set your priorities.

A well-delivered no is reputation too: someone who keeps their promises, because they don't promise what they can't deliver.

English models

- "Thanks for thinking of me. That might be a bit tricky right now."

- "I can't take it on until June, but I could help with the kickoff meeting."
- "Let me see what I can do. I'll check with my manager and get back to you by Thursday."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
that might be a bit tricky	isso pode ser complicado (= provavelmente não)
let me see what I can do	vou ver o que posso fazer
to take something on	assumir algo
a kickoff meeting	reunião de abertura de projeto
thanks for thinking of me	obrigado por lembrar de mim

Practice

A. A colleague asks you to review a 40-page document by tomorrow. Write a soft no with an alternative.

B. Why is it useful to mention your manager when the request comes from another department?

Listen next

Office Lab 54, Saying No Without Saying No. Larissa declines a request by offering something smaller. Listen for "That might be a bit tricky" and "I could…"

Em resumo: Para dizer não a um colega sem estragar a relação, reconheça o pedido, explique o limite e ofereça algo menor ou para depois.

CASE 47

Sick, on Leave, Away

The case

Fábio woke up with a fever on a Tuesday. He thought about his reputation, about probation, and went to work anyway, at an engineering company in Vancouver. At 11 a.m., his manager sent him home: "Please, go home and rest. We don't want the whole team getting sick."

A month later, Fábio asked for two weeks off for his sister's wedding in Brazil, starting ten days later. His manager approved it, but said, "A bit more notice next time would really help."

What was going on

In Canada, coming to work sick isn't seen as dedication. It's seen as a risk to the team. The reputation you build by arriving early and taking notes after hours doesn't depend on showing up sick.

The practical rules (check your company's policies and your province's rules):

- **When you're sick:** let your manager know before your start time, by message or call, in the way your team usually does. Say what needs to be covered.
- **Time off:** ask as far in advance as you can, often several weeks. Before you leave, write a handover note and set up your out-of-office message.
- **During probation:** paid vacation is often earned over your first year, so early time off may be unpaid. Ask before booking travel.

Giving good, early notice is what turns an absence into a demonstration of organization.

English models

When you're sick:

- "Hi Karen, I'm feeling under the weather today, so I'm going to stay home. I'll be offline to rest. Could someone cover the 10 a.m. call?"

Asking for time off:

- "I'd like to request two weeks off in March for my sister's wedding. I wanted to give you as much notice as possible."

Out-of-office:

- "I'm out of the office until March 18. For urgent matters, please contact Tom at..."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
under the weather	meio doente
to call in sick	avisar que está doente
notice	antecedência (aviso com antecedência)
time off	folga, férias
a handover note	nota de passagem de trabalho
out-of-office message	resposta automática de ausência

Practice

A. Write the message to your manager saying you're sick today.

B. List two things you should do before going on vacation.

Listen next

Office Lab 63, Calling In Sick, and Office Lab 27, Asking for Time Off. Listen for "under the weather," "handover note" and "out-of-office message."

Em resumo: Doente, fique em casa e avise antes do horário; férias, peça com semanas de antecedência e deixe tudo passado.

CASE 48

Effort That Builds Reputation, Without Burnout

The case

Mariana took the reputation rule seriously. She arrived at 8:40 and took notes after hours. But little by little, the ten minutes of notes turned into two hours of extra work. By her twelfth week, she was leaving at 8 p.m. every day, answering emails at midnight and making small mistakes from tiredness.

One evening, her director found her alone in the office at 7:50. "Mariana, you're here late again. Is everything okay? What can wait until tomorrow?"

What was going on

This book's rule still stands: arrive early, and after finishing time take ten minutes to write down what you learned and what you promised. Nobody will ask for those minutes, but they build your reputation. That effort is small, steady and sustainable.

Working until 8 p.m. every day is something else. In Canada, when it becomes routine, the reading changes: your manager starts to wonder whether you're overloaded, whether you can't organize your time, or whether you're about to burn out. And mistakes from tiredness wipe out the credit for the extra hours.

The difference:

BUILDS REPUTATION	WEARS IT DOWN
Arriving 10–15 minutes early	Arriving exhausted after little sleep
10 minutes of notes at the end of the day	Two extra hours every day
Staying late on a delivery day	Staying late as a routine
Flagging early when the load is heavy	Hiding the load until you make mistakes

When your director asks, "What can wait?", they're offering help. Take it.

English models

- "Thanks for checking. Honestly, I've been a bit overloaded."
- "Could we look at what can wait until next week?"
- "I'm heading out now. I'll pick this up first thing tomorrow."

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
burned out	esgotado
overloaded	sobrecarregado
what can wait?	o que pode esperar?
to head out	ir embora
first thing tomorrow	logo cedo amanhã

Practice

A. Sort each habit into "builds" or "wears down": arriving 15 minutes early · answering emails at midnight every day · taking notes for 10 minutes after hours · hiding that you're overloaded.

B. Your director asks, "Is everything okay? What can wait until tomorrow?" Write an honest reply.

Listen next

Office Lab 64, Working Too Late. Larissa alone in the office at 7:50 p.m. Listen for "burned out," "overloaded" and "what can wait."

Em resumo: Chegar cedo e anotar dez minutos constrói reputação; ficar até as 20h todo dia desgasta e leva ao esgotamento.

CASE 49

Escalating Without Burning Anyone

The case

André depended on a colleague in another department, Lisa, for the sales data every Monday at a consumer goods company in Mississauga. For the third week in a row, the data arrived on Wednesday, delaying his report.

Irritated, André emailed Lisa's director directly, copying his own manager, to complain about the delays. Lisa heard about it from her director. The next week, she barely spoke to him.

What was going on

In Canada, escalating a problem, taking it to someone with more authority, is normal and sometimes necessary. But there's an order. Skipping the person involved and going straight to their boss is seen as "going behind her back."

The sequence that protects both your reputation and the relationship:

1. **Talk to the person first,** privately, with facts.

2. **If that doesn't work, talk to your own manager.** They decide whether and how to escalate.
3. **Focus on the project, not the person:** the impact of the delay, not Lisa's behaviour.
4. **Propose a solution,** such as a change of deadline or process.

People who escalate this way are seen as problem-solvers. People who escalate like André are seen as problem-makers.

English models

With the person:

- "Hi Lisa, the sales data has come in on Wednesday for the past three weeks, and it's pushing my report back. Is there anything I can do to make Mondays easier on your end?"

With your manager:

- "I wanted to run something by you. I've talked to Lisa about the data delays, but it's still affecting the Monday report. How would you like me to handle it?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to escalate	levar a um nível hierárquico acima
going behind someone's back	agir pelas costas de alguém
to run something by someone	consultar alguém sobre algo
to push back (a date)	atrasar (uma data)
on your end	do seu lado

Practice

A. Put these in order: talk to your manager · propose a solution · talk to the person · focus on the project.

B. Write the message André should have sent Lisa first.

Listen next

Office Lab 66, Escalating a Problem. Karen helps Larissa escalate a problem. Listen for how Karen focuses on the project, not the person.

Em resumo: Antes de escalar, fale com a pessoa; depois, com o seu manager, focando no projeto e não na pessoa.

CASE 50

The 90-Day Conversation

The case

Tatiana reached the last week of her probation at a tech company in Toronto. Her manager booked "a quick chat about your first 90 days." Tatiana didn't sleep that night.

But she had an advantage: 90 days of notes written after hours. The evening before, she opened her notebook and put together one page with her wins, the feedback she had received, and what she had changed after each piece of it.

In the meeting, her manager said, "You're meeting expectations across the board. One area to grow is delegation." Tatiana thanked her, showed her the page and asked, "How can I get better at delegating over the next six months?"

What was going on

The 90-day conversation is rarely a surprise for someone who has tracked their own probation by asking "How am I tracking?" (Case 27). Still, it's worth preparing.

What to bring:

1. **A list of wins,** with numbers.
2. **The feedback you received** and what you changed after each piece. It shows you can learn, one of the four questions from Case 1.
3. **One or two goals** for the coming months.
4. **A question about growth.**

And watch the language: "meeting expectations" means you're doing your job well. It isn't "okay" or "average." If there's criticism, accept it and ask how to improve, as Tatiana did.

On that day you see the concrete result of this book's rule. The reputation you built over 90 days is on the table, and your notes are the proof.

English models

- "I've put together a short summary of my first 90 days. Can I walk you through it?"
- "Here's the feedback you gave me in week 3, and here's what I changed."
- "For the next six months, I'd like to focus on…"
- "How can I get better at delegating?"
- "Is there anything else you'd like to see from me as my probation wraps up?"

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
meeting expectations	atendendo às expectativas (= bom)
exceeding expectations	superando as expectativas
across the board	em todos os aspectos
an area to grow	um ponto a desenvolver
delegation	delegação
to walk someone through	explicar passo a passo

Practice

A. What does "You're meeting expectations" mean? Is it a good or a bad review?

B. Write the four things you would bring to your 90-day conversation.

Listen next

Office Lab 34, How Reviews Work, and Office Lab 36, The Annual Review. Listen for "meeting expectations" and how Larissa reacts to criticism.

Em resumo: Leve à conversa dos 90 dias os seus wins, os feedbacks e o que mudou; "meeting expectations" é elogio, não nota média.

CASE 51

You Passed. Now What?

The case

Gabriel got the confirmation: he had passed probation at an engineering company in Calgary. Relieved, he relaxed. He stopped arriving early, dropped his end-of-day notes and stopped sending updates.

Six months later, at his annual review, his manager said, "You had a really strong start. The last few months have felt a bit flat." A coordinator role that Gabriel wanted went to someone else.

What was going on

Probation ends. Reputation doesn't. The habits that got you here are the same ones that will take you to the next step. Arriving early, notes after hours, flagging early, asking for feedback: none of it was only for probation.

The end of probation is also the moment to start talking about the future. In Canada, nobody offers a promotion to someone who never said they wanted one. And the conversation often starts with questions like "Where do you see yourself in three years?"

Three steps after 90 days:

1. **Keep the habits.**
2. **Tell your manager where you want to go,** with a concrete goal.
3. **Ask what it takes** to get there: a certification, more responsibility, a specific project.

English models

- "Now that I've finished my probation, I'd love to talk about where I could grow here."
- "In three years, I'd like to be leading a small team."
- "What would I need to show to be considered for a coordinator role?"
- "Would you be willing to put my name forward if something comes up?"

If your manager says, "Let's not get ahead of ourselves," they mean: let's take it one step at a time.

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
to pass probation	passar no período de experiência
to put someone's name forward	indicar alguém
to make the case	apresentar bons argumentos
flat	sem brilho, estagnado
let's not get ahead of ourselves	vamos com calma
a certification	uma certificação

Practice

A. Write your answer to "Where do you see yourself in three years?"

B. What did Gabriel do wrong after passing probation?

Listen next

Office Lab 28, Talking About the Future, and Office Lab 73, Asking About the Next Step. Listen for "put your name forward" and "I'm going to push for this."

Em resumo: O probation termina, a reputação não: mantenha os hábitos e diga ao manager, com clareza, aonde você quer chegar.

CASE 52

One Year Later

The case

One year after her first day, Fernanda was still at the distributor in Burnaby, now as a senior analyst. On a Monday morning at 8:45, she noticed a new Brazilian hire at reception, looking at her phone, a little lost.

Fernanda introduced herself, offered her a coffee and walked her to her desk. At the end of the day, before leaving, she gave her some advice: "Chega cedo, e depois do horário tira dez minutos para anotar tudo. Dave is going to tell you that you don't have to. Do it anyway."

At the team meeting that week, Dave told the new colleague, "If you have any questions, Fernanda's your person. Everyone goes to her."

What was going on

That is reputation. Fernanda didn't get there with a brilliant report. She got there with a year of small habits: flagging early, asking well, giving credit, asking for feedback, arriving early, taking notes after hours. None of those habits was ever requested. All of them were noticed.

Probation lasts 90 days. The reputation you build in them lasts much longer. And one day, probably sooner than you think, you'll be the one at reception, welcoming someone new.

English models

- "Hi, are you starting today? I'm Fernanda, I'm on the analytics team. Can I grab you a coffee?"
- "If you have any questions, I'm right over there."
- "Look at you!" (Praise for someone's progress.)

Vocabulary

ENGLISH	PORTUGUÊS
she's your person	ela é a pessoa certa para você procurar
to mentor	orientar
that's a relief	que alívio
look at you	olha só você (elogio)
that's fair	é justo, concordo

Practice

A. Write what you would say to welcome a new colleague on their first day.

B. Write a short letter to yourself one year from now, in English or in Portuguese: what reputation do you want to have built?

Listen next

Office Lab 71, The New Person, and Office Lab 75, One Year Later. Listen for how Larissa repeats, for the new person, the lines she heard on her own first day.

Em resumo: Reputação é um ano de hábitos pequenos que ninguém pediu e todos perceberam; um dia, será você recebendo o próximo brasileiro.

PHRASES THAT ARE PROMISES

In a Canadian office, some short phrases are commitments. Say "I'll get back to you" and never get back, and you lose a little reputation every time. Use these phrases carefully, keep every one, and write down in your end-of-day notes each one you said.

ENGLISH	WHAT YOU PROMISED	EM PORTUGUÊS
"I'll look into it."	I'll investigate.	Vou verificar.
"I'll get back to you."	I'll reply later (say when).	Vou te responder depois.
"I'll take care of it."	I'll handle it.	Pode deixar que eu resolvo.
"I'll keep you posted."	I'll send updates.	Vou te mantendo informado.
"I'm on top of it."	I know what's happening and I'm managing it.	Estou cuidando disso.
"Let's touch base."	Let's talk again to check progress.	Vamos nos falar de novo.
"I'll have it to you by Thursday."	I'll deliver it by Thursday.	Entrego até quinta.
"Leave it with me."	It's my responsibility now.	Deixa comigo.

One simple rule: whenever you can, put a date on the promise. "I'll get back to you by Friday" is far stronger than "I'll get back to you."

ANSWER KEY

Model answers. For open questions, your own answer can be different and still be right; compare it with the model for tone and structure.

Part 1

Case 1. A: A quick, general look at the data, probably one page, to start the conversation. B: "Quick heads-up: the report is taking a bit longer than I expected. I should have it to you by Thursday morning. Let me know if that causes any problems." The key: flag before the deadline, give a new date and leave room for a reply. C: "What would success look like for me at the end of the first 90 days?" or "What are the two or three things you'll be looking at in my probation review?"

Case 2. A: "I'd love one, thanks! Where's the kitchen? I'll come with you." B: Between 8:45 and 8:50. "We start at 9" means working at 9. Arriving earlier shows organization and starts building your reputation. C: "Names: Susan (manager), Mike (team lead, likes hockey). Learned: team meeting is on Tuesdays. Promised: send Mike my availability. Questions: Who approves timesheets?"

Case 3. A: "Hi everyone, I'm Ana. I'm joining as an HR coordinator. I have eight years of experience in recruitment, most recently in Belo Horizonte. I just started learning to skate, so wish me luck! Looking forward to working with you all." B: Sentence 2. It's fine in an interview, but in a team introduction listing degrees and awards sounds like a need to prove your

worth. To mention experience, keep it simple: "I have 12 years of experience in accounting."

Case 4. A: "Hi, I'm new on the marketing team. I've been trying to log in to my email for about an hour and I keep getting an error message. Could you help?" B: meantime. C: False. Asking quickly for help with systems shows you value your own time and the team's.

Case 5. A: Annoyed. A "friendly reminder" with a smiley is often passive-aggressive: polite in form, annoyed in content. B: "Is there anything I should know about how things work in the kitchen?"

Case 6. A: "Pretty good, thanks! I went hiking with some friends. How about you?" B: It gives no detail and doesn't return the question, so the other person has nothing to continue with. C: Hockey, the weather and a new restaurant.

Case 7. A: "Separate bills, please." B: $3 to $4 (15% to 20%). C: "I can't today, but please ask me again. I'd love to join next time."

Case 8. A: "You already know the routine." Gustavo could have said, "Actually, this is all new to me. Could you walk me through it?" B: "Is there a deadline to sign up?" "When do my benefits start?" "Does the company match contributions?"

Case 9. A: Sending short updates and flagging when you're stuck. B: "Hi Jason, just giving you a nudge on the sales data. Any update? I need it for Friday's report." C: "Quick heads-up: the vendor hasn't sent the signed forms, so onboarding is on hold. I see two options: I call their account manager directly today, or we move the start date by a week. Which would you prefer?"

Case 10. A: "I've checked the README and searched the repo, but I can't find the config file for the test environment. Where does it usually live?" B: Try on your own → batch your questions → show what you tried → write the answer down.

Case 11. A: (1) A real apology. (2) "Pardon?" — I didn't hear you. (3) Sympathy. B: "No worries!" and "Anytime!" (or "You bet!", "No problem!").

Case 12. A: "It's Ga-bree-EL, with the stress at the end. But Gabe is fine too!" B: "I'm so sorry, I'm terrible with names. Could you remind me of yours?"

Case 13. A: "1. Done: finished the onboarding modules. 2. Working on: the weekly report. 3. Need help: access to the client database." B: "Really good, thanks. I've put together a few points, if that's okay. And I'd love to hear what a successful first 90 days looks like for you."

Part 2

Case 14. A: "Yesterday I finished the sales report. Today I'm starting the customer analysis. One blocker: I'm waiting on data from marketing." B: 30 to 60 seconds.

Case 15. A: "Thanks for including me. I don't think I'm needed for this one, so I'll skip it, but I'd love to see the notes." B: The person has to leave at 3 sharp, with no extra minutes.

Case 16. A: "Just to build on what Ben said, I think we could use the same template for the Calgary office." B: The team may read your silence as having no opinion or no interest, not as respect.

Case 17. A: "Thanks, Jason. I might be wrong, but are these last year's numbers? I think the new figures came out last week." B: Important feedback. "You might want to" usually means "please do this" (see Case 35).

Case 18. A: Continue the discussion later, with fewer people. It isn't criticism, but someone is expected to set up that conversation. B: "Hi Mark, following up on the budget question from this morning. Are you free for 15 minutes tomorrow to talk it through?"

Case 19. A:

> *Hi team,*
>
> *Thanks for today. Just to recap:*
>
> • Ana: review the contract by Tuesday.
>
> • [Your name]: update the spreadsheet by Friday.
>
> • Next meeting: the 15th.
>
> *Let me know if I missed anything.*
>
> *Thanks, [Your name]*

B: It's useful work for everyone, it makes you visible and it shows you're organized.

Case 20. A: "Sorry, you're breaking up. Could you say that again?" B: Join two minutes early, test your audio and camera, find a quiet place (and stay on mute when you're not speaking).

Case 21. A: "Does 11 a.m. Pacific, 2 p.m. Eastern work for everyone?" B: "Sure! Just to confirm, is that 2 p.m. your time or mine?"

Case 22. A: (1) "Could you send me the documents when you get a chance?" (2) "Could you send me the file today? I need it for the 4 p.m. meeting. Thanks!" B: "Hi Dave,"

Case 23. A: "Hi! Quick question: do you have the client's contact details? Thanks!" B: "Sure, will do! I'll send it over before 3."

Case 24. A: "Hi, any update on this?" → "Just circling back" → "As per my previous email." B: "Hi Kim, thanks for the reminder. I'll have the report to you by noon today."

Case 25. A: "Sure. Do you need them by a specific time?" B: By the end of today. C: "I can get most of it done by Friday, but I'll need until Monday for the last section. Would that work?"

Case 26. A: "Which days does the team usually come in?" B: It's feedback. Go in on the days your team goes in, be available during core hours, and consider going in more often during probation.

Part 3

Case 27. A: "I closed 14 support tickets, up from 9 last week." / "I finished the vendor onboarding two days early." B: "How am I tracking?" It means you know every week how you're doing, so there are no surprises at the 90-day review.

Case 28. A: "I'd be happy to help with this. Right now I'm working on the budget, the client report and the vendor review. If I take this on, one of them will slip. Can you help me prioritize?" B: He hid the problem. When it happened again, his manager stopped trusting that he would flag issues in time.

Case 29. A: "Just so I'm clear, do you mean shorter, or more focused on the main recommendations?" B: She guessed what her director wanted instead of asking.

Case 30. A: "It's coming along well! The slides are done, and I'm finishing the speaker notes today." B: False. Most of the time it's just a friendly question about progress.

Case 31. A: "Thank you, I'm really happy with how it went. And Ana's research made a big difference." B: It can sound as if you're correcting the person or don't believe in your own work, and it erases your contribution.

Case 32. A: Reply to client emails faster. B: "Thanks, that's really helpful. Is there a response time you'd like me to aim for? I'll start checking my inbox first thing every morning."

Case 33. A: (1) It needs a lot more work. (2) Probably not, at least for now. B: "What would need to happen for this to move forward?" or "Would it be worth putting together a short proposal, or is now not the right time?"

Case 34. A: "What's one thing I could have done better on yesterday's report?" B: It's easy to answer politely ("You're doing great!") without saying anything useful.

Case 35. A: Sentence 2. B: "Good point, I'll add one from now on."

Case 36. A: "Do you have a minute? I might be wrong, but I think the email says the 14th, and the meeting is on the 15th. I just wanted to flag it before it goes out." B: Privately, early, gently and with the data.

Case 37. A: "Hi Kate, I'm new on the sales team. Would you be up for a quick 15-minute coffee next week? I'd love to understand how HR works

with us." B: He already knew the person in finance from a chat at the company barbecue.

Case 38. A: "I cut the processing time from three days to one." B: "This week: 1. Finished the Q3 cost report. 2. Fixed the supplier invoice issue. 3. Next week: starting the inventory review."

Case 39. A: "I'd love that! Are you free Wednesday or Thursday next week?" B: "Not soon." It's a polite way to put something off, not necessarily a rejection.

Part 4

Case 40. A: Tell your manager → take responsibility → bring a solution → say what you'll change. B: "Do you have a minute? I made a mistake and I want you to hear it from me."

Case 41. A: "I'm sorry about the error on the invoice. The corrected version is attached." B: Long explanations sound like excuses and make the mistake seem bigger than it was.

Case 42. A: "Hi Sarah, I wanted to give you a heads-up: I'm still waiting on the numbers from operations, so Friday is looking tight. Would Monday work instead? In the meantime, I can send you the first two sections on Friday." B: The reason, a new date, and what you can deliver earlier.

Case 43. A: "Hey Josh, do you have a few minutes? From what I can see, the feature needs about six weeks, not two. Going forward, could you check with me before we commit to dates? For now, how about we call the client together with an updated timeline?" B: In public, it sounded like an attack. The focus moved from the deadline to the conflict.

Case 44. A: "I'm really glad the freight idea I suggested is getting traction. Happy to help develop it." B: Put his ideas in writing, in a short email or the team channel.

Case 45. A: "Looks like the system is down. While IT looks into it, I'll walk you through the main points, and I'll send a new time for the live demo by end of day." B: Your own answer. Examples: slides saved offline, printed material, an exercise that doesn't need the system.

Case 46. A: "Thanks for thinking of me. Forty pages by tomorrow might be a bit tricky, but I could review the executive summary today. Would that help?" B: Your manager sets your priorities. Mentioning them protects you and your current work.

Case 47. A: "Hi Karen, I'm feeling under the weather today, so I'm going to stay home. Could someone cover my 10 a.m. call?" B: Write a handover note and set up your out-of-office message.

Case 48. A: Builds: arriving 15 minutes early; taking notes for 10 minutes after hours. Wears down: answering emails at midnight every day; hiding that you're overloaded. B: "Thanks for checking. Honestly, I've been a bit overloaded. Could we look at what can wait until next week?"

Case 49. A: Talk to the person → talk to your manager → focus on the project → propose a solution. B: "Hi Lisa, the sales data has come in on Wednesday for the past three weeks, and it's pushing my report back. Is there anything I can do to make Mondays easier on your end?"

Case 50. A: You're doing your job well. It's a good review. B: A list of wins with numbers; the feedback you received and what you changed; one or two goals; a question about growth.

Case 51. A: "In three years, I'd like to be leading a small team. I'm also planning to get my PMP certification." B: He dropped the habits that built his reputation and never talked to his manager about the future.

Case 52. A: "Hi, are you starting today? I'm [your name], I'm on the finance team. Can I grab you a coffee? If you have any questions, I'm right over there." B: Your own answer.

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Ron Taylor is a Canadian communication consultant with three decades of experience teaching English through individual, personalized lessons. Over the years he has taught students from around the world; today he works exclusively with Brazilian professionals building careers in Canada: auditors, engineers, lawyers, IT specialists, managers and their families.

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THE COURSE: YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS ON THE JOB

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the email that needs the right tone, the feedback conversation, the request for more time, and the 90-day review itself, with a Canadian communication consultant who tells you exactly how you sound.

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